

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

Book One

NOT LIKE THIS

by

MRETYUN JAI B

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"Every decision creates a future.

Some decisions create two."

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Can Love Survive?

Book One – Not Like This

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First Edition

Printed in India

For every overthinker...
Who replayed conversations
long after they ended.
Who wondered,
"What if I had stayed silent?"
Who carried feelings
they never found the courage to say.
This story is for you

Before You Begin...

This is not a story about perfect love.

It is not a story about heroes or villains.

It is a story about ordinary people...

ordinary conversations...

ordinary mistakes...

and one decision...

that quietly changed two lives forever.

**If you have ever looked back at your life
and wondered,**

"What if I had chosen differently?"

perhaps...

**you'll find a part of yourself somewhere in
these page**

About the Author & this Novel

Author – **Mretyun Jai B**

I never liked reading books, and I had never even finished one completely. Yet, I ended up writing a novel. It's funny, isn't it?

I wrote this book because I wanted others to experience my overthinking and the emotions I went through during some of the most important moments of my life.

This novel is inspired by both real and imagined events, so it is not entirely based on true incidents. It is a story about love, choices, distance, hope, and the emotions that come with them.

Whenever I overthink, I write. That's how this novel came to life.

Author's Note

"Thank you for spending your time with Mithran's story.

Book One - Not Like This, is not a story about losing love.

It is a story about how one decision can quietly change the course of two lives.

If you've ever replayed a conversation in your head, wished you had chosen different words, or wondered how life might have been after one different decision... this story was written for you.

Thank you for reading.

— MRETYUN JAI B"

TABLE OF CONTENTS

<i>Part VI - The Silence</i>	<i>14</i>
Chapter Twenty-Six	14
Chapter Twenty-Seven.....	27
Chapter Twenty-Eight.....	43
Chapter Twenty-Nine.....	61
Chapter Thirty	80
Chapter Thirty-One	90
Chapter Thirty-Two.....	112
Chapter Thirty-Three	132
Chapter Thirty-Four	147
Chapter Thirty-Five	165

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

PROLOGUE

There are stories we proudly tell.

And there are stories we spend years trying to forget.

Mine...

somehow became both.

If you're holding this book...

thank you.

I hope that by the time you reach the final page,

you'll understand why one ordinary night...

changed everything.

— M.

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PART I

Every story begins with a hello...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

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**This Story begins with the message
Mithran chose to send...**

Part VI - The Silence

Chapter Twenty-Six

The Message I Sent

The bus reached my hometown early in the morning.
The journey had ended.
But the thoughts inside my head hadn't.
I hadn't slept the entire night.
Every time I closed my eyes...
I saw the same memories.
The YouKnow cards.
Her smiling while looking at her phone.
The silence between us after July 17.
The quiet ride to the bus stand.
That final...
"Goodbye."
When I reached home...
my parents asked the usual questions.
"How was the journey?"
"Did you sleep?"
"Are you hungry?"
I simply smiled.
"Yeah... everything's fine."
I wasn't lying to them.
I just didn't know how to explain something I didn't
even understand myself.
I went into my room.
Closed the door.
Kept my bag in one corner.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Sat on the edge of the bed.
The room was completely silent.
For the first time since leaving Kerala...
I was alone.
I unlocked my phone.
Our WhatsApp chat was still open.
The last messages we had exchanged before
everything became awkward were still there.
I scrolled upwards.
Then down again.
Again.
And again.
As though somewhere inside those messages...
I'd find the answer I had been searching for.
I kept asking myself the same question.
"Was it really my mistake?"
Then another voice inside me replied,
"No... she stopped talking."
A few seconds later...
another thought appeared.
"Maybe she didn't even realise it."
Every answer created another question.
The more I tried convincing myself to leave it alone...
the more impossible it became.
I had never felt this helpless before.
Not because we had argued.
Because we hadn't.
We had remained silent.
And somehow...
that silence had hurt more than any argument ever
could.
The clock slowly moved past midnight.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

It was now...

July 23.

I looked at our chat one more time.

My fingers rested above the keyboard.

For almost ten minutes...

I typed nothing.

I simply stared at the blinking cursor.

Finally...

I couldn't hold it anymore.

I started typing.

Not because I wanted to fight.

Because I wanted answers.

I wanted to know...

what had happened after July 17.

Why everything suddenly changed.

I pressed send.

"why did you not speak to me properly"

A few seconds later...

another message.

"what happened to you after 17th July"

Then...

the question that had been hurting me ever since I left Kerala.

"did I do something wrong"

After sending those three messages...

I placed my phone beside me.

For a moment...

I felt lighter.

As though I had finally spoken the words that had been trapped inside my heart.

But almost immediately...

another feeling replaced that relief.

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Fear.

"What if I misunderstood everything?"

"What if she becomes angry?"

"What if I shouldn't have sent those messages?"

I picked up the phone again.

There was still no reply.

Every second suddenly felt longer than it actually was.

I kept looking at the screen.

Locked it.

Unlocked it.

Opened WhatsApp again.

Nothing.

Minutes slowly passed.

Outside...

the world was asleep.

Inside my room...

only the light from my phone remained.

Then...

my phone vibrated.

It was her.

For a second...

I forgot how to breathe.

I opened the chat immediately.

She had replied.

And without knowing it...

those replies were about to change everything
between us.

My heart was beating faster than it ever had.

I opened the chat.

She had replied.

Not angrily.

Not coldly.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Simply...

trying to explain what she thought had happened.

She wrote,

"What noo I am texting u rn know, If I wasn't talking I woundnt have done that, U r just overthinking"

I read that sentence again.

And again.

But somehow...

it wasn't the answer I had been searching for.

She was talking about now.

I was thinking about those five days in Kerala.

So I replied,

"I am not telling now"

A few moments later...

another message appeared.

"Same here I am not talking abt now,Past decisions of mine influence the future so the "now" if, I am talking then it means I did talk to you"

I stared at the screen.

Somewhere...

both of us were talking about the same incident.

Yet...

we were understanding it differently.

I replied,

"That's what I am watching"

Almost immediately...

she answered,

"I dont think so, I did talk"

I closed my eyes for a second.

I wasn't trying to prove she was wrong.

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I only wanted to know...
why everything had suddenly changed.
So I asked,

"what happened to u??"

This time...

her reply was much longer.

**"idkk nthng felt off to me, it was fine only, U
were busy with ur phone so I don't really know
wt u r talking abt, and more over if u wanted to
talk or something u could have just talked to me
more but u were continuing to watch phone so
yeah I don't feel like there was no talking"**

I kept reading those words.

One sentence stood out.

"U were busy with ur phone..."

I quietly put my own phone down.

For a few seconds...

I couldn't type anything.

She thought...

I wasn't interested in talking to her.

But the truth was completely different.

I had only looked at my phone because...

I believed she wasn't interested in talking to me.

While she thought I was avoiding her...

I thought she was avoiding me.

Two people.

One misunderstanding.

Neither of us knew what the other was actually
feeling.

I finally replied,

"You didn't talk to me , that's why I watch"

The typing indicator appeared again.

She responded almost immediately.

"Dudee I wake up and I take my time for all coffee and bfast and I have work after that, atleast u could have told something asked right there if u had a prblm, nows literally not the time for u to act all like this , oh please it doesn't take a min for u to keep ur phone aside and ask me to talk or watch a movie or play uno or cards, Oh stop well but I did that always didn't I , oh please I always called u and my mom to play cards before my sleep time, I didn't wanted to stay awake when I had clg to start in like 2 or 3 days, And well I did watch tv and the movie that day"

I read every single line slowly.

She wasn't denying what had happened.

She was telling me...

she had tried in her own way.

She believed she had made the effort.

I believed she hadn't.

Neither of us was lying.

We had simply remembered those days differently.

I looked back at the messages.

The tears that had stopped after reaching home... slowly returned.

Not because of her words.

Because for the first time...

I realised that Maybe we had both been hurting during the same week.

Without either of us knowing it.

Still...

my heart wasn't satisfied.

It wasn't asking for an explanation anymore.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

It was asking for one thing.
The thing it had wanted since July 17.
So I replied,
"I didn't tell u to awake till midnight, all I want is to talk to me"
I stared at the screen.
Waiting.
Hoping.
Wondering whether she would finally understand...
what I had been trying to say from the beginning.
For a few seconds...
there was no reply.
The typing indicator appeared.
Disappeared.
Then appeared again.
I kept staring at the screen.
My heart was hoping that somehow...
this conversation would bring us back to the way we
used to be.
Then...
her next message arrived.
"Also stop finding excuses, I have tried everything , from initiating convo to playing and everything, And u think back it was me who initiated all fucking shit"
I read that message slowly.
Then once more.
She wasn't trying to hurt me.
She was frustrated.
She genuinely believed she had tried.
And Maybe...
from her point of view...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

she really had.
For the first time during the conversation...
I realised something.
We weren't fighting because one of us was right.
We were fighting because we had experienced the
same five days in two completely different ways.
She remembered trying.
I remembered waiting.
She remembered calling me to play.
I remembered feeling unwanted.
Neither memory was fake.
Neither feeling was wrong.
I looked at the keyboard.
My fingers stopped moving.
I suddenly didn't want this conversation to become
another wound.
So I typed,
"I don't want to make this a big problem"
The reply came almost immediately.
"ohh that's a bit late now isn't it"
Those words hurt.
Not because they were rude.
Because they were true.
By the time we were trying to explain ourselves...
the misunderstanding had already grown too large.
I looked at the screen for a long time.
There were so many things I wanted to say.
So many things I had never told her.
Not about love.
Not about feelings.
Just...
about how much her friendship meant to me.

I stopped thinking.

And simply wrote whatever my heart wanted to say.

Exactly as it was.

"Naa yen ipdi pesunenaa , enta pesura oreya aalu nee than , ippa neeye enta Olunga pesalana enakku epdi, nethu night fulla naa thoongala "yen nee enta pesala" nu yosichutey irrundhen , ennala mudiyala , nethu maari naa ennikum aludhadhu kedaiyaadhu , ippayum ennala alugaiya control panna mudiyala, yen shirt collar full ah eeram aaiduchu, so adhunaala than naa ipdi pesunen, naa edhuvum thappu pannirundha sorry, and Pesa pidikalana pidikala nu solliru, but don't ignore me". In English -> (Why did I talk like that? You're the only person I talk to, and now if even you don't talk to me properly, what am I supposed to do?

I didn't sleep at all last night. I kept thinking, "Why didn't you talk to me?" I just couldn't handle it. I've never cried like I did last night, and even now I can't control my tears. My shirt collar is completely soaked because of how much I've been crying.

That's why I spoke like that. If I did anything wrong, I'm sorry. And if you don't like talking to me, just tell me that you don't. But please, don't ignore me.)

After sending that message...

I didn't feel angry anymore.

I didn't even care who was right.

For the first time since July 17...

I had finally told her the truth.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Not about the misunderstanding.
About my pain.
I kept waiting.
One minute.
Five minutes.
Ten minutes.
There was no reply.
I continued staring at the screen.
Every small vibration from my phone made me hope
it was her.
It never was.
Hours passed.
Night slowly became morning.
Outside...
the first sunlight entered my room.
Inside...
I was still looking at the same chat.
Even after everything...
I couldn't end the conversation like that.
So...
on the morning of July 23...
I sent one final message.
**"Reached home, Nethu apdi pesunadhukku sry ,
theriyaama pesiten apdi, edhuvum manasula
vachukaadha ". In English -> (sorry for speaking
like that on yesterday, pls forget that and don't
mind this)**
I pressed send.
This time...
I didn't ask any questions.
I didn't expect explanations.
I only apologised.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Then...
I waited.
Morning became afternoon.
Afternoon became evening.
There was still no reply.
Two days later...
I noticed that she had seen all my messages.
Every single one.
The blue ticks appeared.
But...
no reply came.
Not a single word.
For a long time...
I kept opening the chat.
Thinking...
"Maybe she'll reply later."
She never did.
A few days later...
I tried messaging her on Instagram.
The messages were seen.
But they remained unanswered.
The silence that had begun in Kerala...
had now followed us home.
Then...
one day...
her Instagram account disappeared.
She had deactivated it.
For a few seconds...
I simply stared at the screen.
I didn't know whether she had deactivated it because
of this conversation...
or for some completely different reason.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I never asked.
I never found out.
From that day onwards...
our daily phone calls disappeared.
The long late-night conversations ended.
The random "Have you eaten?" messages stopped.
The laughter...
the jokes...
the ordinary conversations that had once filled our
days...
quietly vanished.
There was no official ending.
No final goodbye.
No decision to stop being friends.
Just...
silence.
A silence that grew a little bigger every day.
Until one day...
it became our new normal.
Looking back now...
I don't remember who won that argument.
Because no one did.
I only remember losing the one person I never
wanted to lose.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

Living Like Strangers

Life didn't stop after that day.
Even though I wanted it to.
The world continued moving as if nothing had happened.
College reopened.
Assignments came one after another.
Internal exams.
Semester exams.
Projects.
Placement training.
Slowly...
I forced myself to become busy.
Not because I had moved on.
Because staying busy was easier than thinking.
Whenever my friends called me to bunk classes...
I went with them.
If they planned a movie...
I joined.
If someone wanted to go out for tea...
I went.
Sometimes we spent hours talking about random things.
Sometimes we laughed so much that my stomach hurt.
For a few hours...
I forgot everything.
But the moment I returned to my room...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

everything came back.
I would unlock my phone.
Open WhatsApp.
Look at our old chat.
Then quietly lock it again.
Every single day.
It had become a habit.
A habit I never managed to break.
Slowly...
my final year came to an end.
Campus placements began.
Every student was nervous.
Everyone wanted a job before graduation.
I was no different.
I attended interviews.
Prepared for aptitude rounds.
Practised coding.
Waited outside interview halls with hundreds of other students.
Then...
one ordinary afternoon...
my phone rang.
I had been selected.
For a few seconds...
I simply stared at the screen.
I had done it.
After months of preparation...
I finally had my first job.
My parents were happier than I was.
Relatives started calling.
Friends congratulated me.
For one evening...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

everything felt perfect.
Then...
I looked at the offer letter.
Location: Kerala.
My smile slowly disappeared.
I didn't know whether to be happy...
or afraid.
Happy...
because I had achieved something I had worked hard
for.
Afraid...
because I knew exactly where I would be staying.
My aunt's house.
Aashika's house.
For a long time...
I simply looked at that one word.
Kerala.
The same city that had given me my happiest
memories...
and my most painful goodbye.
Graduation arrived.
Convocation ended.
College life quietly became another memory.
Around the same time...
Aashika also completed her graduation.
Life was moving forward for both of us.
Just...
not together anymore.
A few weeks later...
I packed my bags once again.
Just like I had done so many times before.
Only this time...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I wasn't travelling for holidays.
I was travelling to begin my career.
When I reached Kerala...
everything looked familiar.
The roads hadn't changed.
The apartment hadn't changed.
The people hadn't changed.
Only...
our relationship had.
When I entered the house...
everyone welcomed me warmly.
My aunt smiled.
My uncle asked about my journey.
Everyone spoke exactly the way they always had.
It felt like nothing had changed.
Then...
I saw Aashika.
For a brief moment...
our eyes met.
She smiled politely.
"Hi."
I smiled back.
"Hi."
That was all.
No long conversations.
No teasing.
No,
"How was your journey?"
No,
"Have you eaten?"
Just...
one word.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

That evening...
we all sat together for dinner.
My aunt served food.
My uncle talked about work.
My parents called to ask whether I had reached safely.
Everyone at the table was talking.
Except us.
If someone asked her something...
she answered.
If someone asked me something...
I answered.
But neither of us started a conversation with the
other.
Not because we hated each other.
Because we didn't know how.
The next morning...
our routines quietly began.
She left for work.
I left for my office.
In the evening...
we both returned home.
Had dinner with the family.
Then went to our own rooms.
The same routine repeated itself.
Again.
And again.
And again.
Days slowly became weeks.
Weeks quietly became months.
We lived in the same house.
Walked past each other almost every day.
Shared the same dining table.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Watched the same television.
Heard each other's laughter while talking to other
family members.
Yet...
our conversations never went beyond,
"Good morning."
"Did you eat?"
"I'm leaving."
"Okay."
Sometimes...
I wondered how two people who once spent hours
talking every night...
had become two people who couldn't even hold a
conversation for two minutes.
I never found an answer.
I simply accepted it.
Because by then...
silence had become part of our everyday life.
Months slowly passed.
The house never became uncomfortable.
It simply became...
quiet.
Not for everyone.
Only for us.
Every morning followed the same routine.
I woke up.
Got ready for work.
Came downstairs.
Sometimes she was already having breakfast.
Sometimes I reached first.
If our eyes met...
one of us would simply say,

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"Morning."

The other would reply,

"Morning."

Then both of us quietly continued eating.

During weekends...

the family usually planned to go somewhere.

Sometimes shopping.

Sometimes a temple.

Sometimes a relative's house.

Sometimes just dinner outside.

Everyone happily agreed.

So did we.

We travelled in the same car.

Sometimes she sat near the window.

I sat somewhere behind.

Sometimes I looked outside.

Sometimes I looked at my phone.

Neither of us tried to start a conversation.

The silence between us had become so normal...

that nobody else even noticed it.

Whenever relatives asked,

"You two don't talk much nowadays?"

One of us would smile.

"Nothing like that."

Then the conversation would move somewhere else.

Only we knew...

there was everything like that.

Festivals came and went.

Deepavali.

Pongal.

Birthdays.

Family functions.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

The house was filled with lights.
Guests.
Laughter.
Children running around.
Everything looked exactly the same as it had years ago.
We stood together in family photographs.
Smiled when the camera clicked.
Then quietly walked away after the photo was taken.
Looking at those pictures later...
nobody could have guessed anything had changed.
Our smiles looked real.
Only we knew...
they lasted only until the camera disappeared.
Sometimes...
my aunt would ask,
"Mithran... take Aashika with you while going."
Or,
"Aashika... ask Mithran if he wants anything."
Those were probably the longest conversations we had.
Not because we wanted them to be.
Because someone else had started them.
There were evenings when everyone watched television together.
My aunt kept talking during every serial.
Sometimes everyone discussed the news.
Sometimes cricket.
Sometimes politics.
I sat on one side of the sofa.
She sat on the other.
The distance between us was only a few feet.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Yet...

it felt much farther than the hundreds of kilometres
between Trichy and Kerala.

Dinner became another silent routine.

We all ate together.

Passed the dishes.

Asked for water.

Thanked each other.

Everything looked perfectly normal.

If someone had visited our house for the first time...
they would never have guessed there had once been a
friendship that lasted through childhood, phone calls,
late-night conversations, lockdowns, and countless
memories.

Occasionally...

our family visited nearby places.

Parks.

Restaurants.

Shopping malls.

Family gatherings.

We walked together with everyone else.

Sometimes...

we accidentally ended up walking side by side.

For a few seconds...

neither of us spoke.

Then someone else would join us.

The moment would disappear.

There were times when I wanted to ask,

"How's work?"

Or,

"How are you?"

Simple questions.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Questions that would've taken only a few seconds.
But every time...
something stopped me.
Not my ego.
Fear.
Fear that she'd answer politely...
and the conversation would end there.
I didn't know which hurt more.
The silence...
or the possibility that we had truly become strangers.
Sometimes...
I noticed her laughing while talking to my sister.
Or helping my aunt in the kitchen.
Or sitting with relatives.
Seeing her smile made me genuinely happy.
At the same time...
it quietly reminded me that the only place where that
smile no longer reached...
was me.
Days slowly became months.
Months slowly became a year.
Then another.
Life around us continued growing.
Promotions.
Salary hikes.
New responsibilities.
New routines.
Everything changed.
Except one thing.
Neither of us ever spoke about July 23 again.
It remained buried beneath two years of ordinary
days...

where everyone believed we were living together as before.
Only the readers...
and the two of us...
knew that somewhere between those ordinary days...
a friendship had quietly stopped breathing.
Life slowly settled into a routine.
Wake up.
Go to work.
Come back home.
Sleep.
Repeat.
Days became weeks.
Weeks became months.
Before I realised it...
almost two years had passed.
During those two years...
another chapter of Aashika's life had quietly begun.
She had also joined a company in Kerala.
Every morning...
she would get ready for work just like I did.
Sometimes she left before me.
Sometimes after me.
Sometimes we crossed each other near the front door.
A simple,
"Bye."
"Bye."
That was enough.
The strange thing about silence is...
after living with it for long enough...
it starts feeling normal.
Not comfortable.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Just...
normal.
One evening...
I returned from work earlier than usual.
As I entered the apartment...
I saw Aashika sitting in the living room.
She was talking on the phone.
She looked happy.
She smiled.
Laughed.
Then continued talking.
The moment she noticed me...
she politely nodded her head.
I nodded back.
Then quietly went to my room.
I didn't think much about it.
People talk to their friends.
Their colleagues.
Their relatives.
There was nothing unusual.
As weeks passed...
I slowly started noticing something.
Whenever I came back from work...
sometimes she would still be talking on the phone.
Sometimes she smiled while replying to messages.
Sometimes she'd laugh quietly while looking at her screen.
It reminded me of another evening.
July 17.
The YouKnow cards.
That memory quietly returned.
I immediately pushed it away.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"Don't overthink again."
I told myself.
One morning...
while getting ready for work...
I happened to look outside the apartment balcony.
A company cab had stopped downstairs.
She got into it.
Another employee was already sitting inside.
They smiled at each other before the cab left.
There was nothing wrong with that.
They worked in the same company.
It was completely normal.
I knew that.
Yet...
my heart still became heavy.
As months passed...
I heard his name occasionally.
Not from her.
From family conversations.
My aunt would casually ask,
"How was work today?"
She would answer,
"Good."
Sometimes she'd mention a few colleagues.
Sometimes she'd tell funny incidents from the office.
I quietly listened.
Without saying anything.
One evening...
our family decided to have dinner outside.
While waiting for the food...
everyone was talking.
My uncle asked Aashika about her office.

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She smiled and started explaining something that had happened that day.
She mentioned that colleague again.
Everyone laughed at the funny story.
Even I smiled.
But inside...
something quietly hurt.
I never asked,
"Who is he?"
I never asked,
"Are you both close?"
I never asked anything.
Not because I didn't want to know.
Because I felt I had lost the right to ask.
Sometimes...
I saw her leave for work.
Sometimes...
I saw her come back.
Sometimes...
I saw her smiling while replying to messages.
Everything I saw was completely ordinary.
But my heart wasn't ordinary anymore.
It searched for meanings where there were none.
It created questions nobody had asked.
Every night...
I reminded myself.
"She can talk to anyone she wants."
"She owes you nothing."
"You are just her cousin."
"You lost the friendship long ago."
I repeated those sentences so many times...
that eventually...

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I stopped arguing with them.
The more I accepted reality...
the quieter I became.
Not only around her.
Around everyone.
Work kept me busy.
Life kept moving.
Salary increased.
Responsibilities increased.
Projects changed.
Teams changed.
The calendar kept moving forward.
But whenever I returned home...
the house remained exactly the same.
The same dining table.
The same living room.
The same staircase.
The same person.
Only...
our conversations never returned.
There were moments when I accidentally looked at
her...
and remembered the girl who once stayed awake
talking to me until midnight.
The girl who shared her day with me.
The girl who laughed at my terrible jokes.
The girl who asked whether I had eaten.
Then I looked back at the present.
She had changed.
I had changed.
Life had changed.
Maybe...

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that was all.
One evening...
while lying on my bed after work...
I quietly realised something.
I wasn't waiting for her message anymore.
I had stopped expecting one.
Not because I had moved on.
Because hope had become too painful.
Those two years taught me something I had never
wanted to learn.
Sometimes...
people don't leave your life.
They simply stop being part of it.
And somehow...
that hurts even more.
Near the end of my second year in Kerala...
I made a decision.
Not because I wanted to run away.
Because I wanted to begin again.
For the first time in my life...
I started looking beyond India.
Beyond my job.
Beyond the city that carried every memory of her.
I opened my laptop...
and searched for something I had never seriously
considered before.
Higher Studies Abroad.

Chapter Twenty-Eight

A Different Sky

By the end of my second year in Kerala...
work had become routine.
Every day felt almost identical.
Wake up.
Go to the office.
Come back.
Sleep.
Repeat.
Life was moving...
but I wasn't.
Somewhere inside me...
I still felt stuck.
One evening after returning from work...
I opened my laptop.
Instead of watching a movie or scrolling through my
phone...
I searched for universities.
Australia.
Canada.
United Kingdom.
New Zealand.
I wasn't searching because I hated my job.
I was searching because I wanted a fresh beginning.
A place where nothing reminded me of July 22.
For the next few months...
that became my routine after work.
University websites.

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Course details.

Scholarships.

Application forms.

English language requirements.

Educational loans.

Everything was new to me.

Sometimes I got confused.

Sometimes I almost gave up.

But every time...

I told myself,

"If I stay here forever... I'll never really move forward."

Around the same time...

my father called me one evening.

"I have a friend in Australia."

"He has been living there for many years."

"He May be able to help you."

That one phone call changed everything.

A few days later...

my father introduced me to his friend through a video call.

He patiently explained the admission process.

The universities.

Accommodation.

Student life.

Part-time jobs.

Things I had never even thought about.

For the first time...

Australia no longer felt like a dream.

It felt possible.

Over the following weeks...

I completed every document one by one.

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Passport.
Educational certificates.
Statement of Purpose.
Financial documents.
Application forms.
Medical tests.
There always seemed to be another paper waiting.
But slowly...
everything came together.
Then...
one ordinary afternoon...
an email arrived.
My application had been accepted.
I had received admission into a university in Australia.
For a long time...
I simply stared at the screen.
After dreaming about it for months...
it had finally become real.
The next step was the hardest.
I had to resign from my job.
The company where I had spent two years.
The city where I had learned to live with silence.
The house that still carried every memory of Aashika.
When I submitted my resignation...
my manager wished me luck.
My colleagues congratulated me.
Everyone was excited for my future.
I smiled and thanked them.
But inside...
I knew I was saying goodbye to much more than a
workplace.
At home...

everyone started preparing for my departure.
My mother packed things I didn't even think I'd need.
Medicines.
Snacks.
Homemade powders.
My father kept giving advice.
"Take care of your passport."
"Don't skip your meals."
"Call us every day."
My sister kept teasing me.
"Don't forget us after going abroad."
For the first time in many years...
our house was filled with both excitement and
sadness.
Aashika knew I was leaving.
I knew she knew.
But...
we never spoke about it.
Not once.
No "All the best."
No "Take care."
No goodbye.
Just...
the same quiet distance we had lived with for two
years.
The day of my flight finally arrived.
My suitcases were packed.
Every document had been checked at least five times.
There was nothing left to do.
Except leave.
Our entire family came to the airport.
My parents.

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My sister.
Some close relatives.
Everyone smiled while taking photos.
Everyone kept saying,
"We're proud of you."
I smiled too.
But I could see something else in their eyes.
They were trying not to cry.
After the final security announcement...
it was time.
My mother hugged me tightly.
She couldn't stop crying.
My father tried to stay strong.
But his eyes became wet too.
My sister hugged me and said,
"Call us after you land."
I nodded.
Unable to say much.
For a few seconds...
I looked at all of them.
The people who had been beside me my entire life.
Then...
I picked up my bag.
Turned around.
And walked towards immigration.
I didn't look back immediately.
Because I knew...
if I did...
I might not be able to walk away.
A few minutes later...
I finally turned.
They were still standing there.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Still waving.
Still smiling through their tears.
I raised my hand one last time.
'Then disappeared beyond the security gate.
A few hours later...
the flight took off.
As the lights of India slowly disappeared beneath the
clouds...
I quietly looked out of the window.
'This wasn't just another journey.
It was the first time in my life...
I was leaving my country.
Leaving my family.
Leaving my memories.
Leaving everything that had made me who I was.
When I landed in Australia...
everything felt unfamiliar.
'The roads looked different.
'The weather felt different.
'The people spoke differently.
Even the silence sounded different.
I had finally reached the country I had dreamed
about.
A new beginning.
A new sky.
A new life.
Yet...
when night came...
I opened my phone.
Looked at my family's photos.
'Then...
without even realizing it...

my fingers paused for a second on Aashika's old chat.
I quietly locked my phone.
Looked outside my hostel window.
And realised something.
No matter how far I travelled...
home wasn't something I could leave behind.
Because some parts of home...
had followed me across the ocean.
The first few weeks in Australia felt strange.
Everything was unfamiliar.
The streets.
The classrooms.
The weather.
Even the silence around me felt different.
Back in India...
I always knew where I was going.
Here...
even buying groceries felt like an adventure.
Sometimes I walked into the wrong train.
Sometimes I missed my stop.
Sometimes I couldn't understand the accent of the
people around me.
I smiled awkwardly.
They smiled back.
Little by little...
I learned.
University classes began.
The campus was much bigger than I had imagined.
Students from different countries walked together.
Different languages.
Different cultures.
Different dreams.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

For the first time...
I realised how small my world had been.
My days slowly became busy.
Morning lectures.
Afternoon practicals.
Assignments.
Group projects.
Late-night submissions.
There was hardly any free time.
And Maybe...
that was exactly what I needed.
Being busy left less room for overthinking.
Living abroad wasn't easy.
Everything was expensive.
I didn't want to depend on my parents for every
expense.
They had already done enough for me.
So...
I started searching for a part-time job.
After many applications...
I finally found one.
It wasn't a glamorous job.
Sometimes I worked in the evenings.
Sometimes on weekends.
Sometimes after classes.
The work was tiring.
Standing for long hours.
Returning home late.
Then completing assignments before sleeping.
Some nights...
I slept only for a few hours.
At the end of every month...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

after paying my own expenses...
I sent a small amount of money back home.
It wasn't much.
But every time my mother called and said,
"We received it."
I felt proud.
For the first time...
I wasn't just studying.
I was also supporting my family in my own small way.
Months slowly passed.
Australia no longer felt foreign.
It slowly started feeling familiar.
I found my favourite coffee shop near the university.
I learned which train to take without checking Google
Maps.
I even started understanding the local slang.
Life...
was slowly moving forward.
One thing, however...
never returned.
My interest in love.
After everything that had happened...
I had convinced myself that relationships weren't
meant for me.
Whenever my friends spoke about dating...
I simply smiled and changed the topic.
My heart had quietly closed that chapter.
Or at least...
that's what I believed.
During one of my classes...
our professor announced a semester project.
Students were divided into small groups.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

That was when I first met her.
A girl from Australia.
She introduced herself with a smile.
"Hi..."
"I'm Lily."
I smiled politely.
"I'm Mithran."
That was all.
Nothing extraordinary.
Just two classmates assigned to the same project.
Over the next few weeks...
we met regularly for assignments.
Sometimes in the library.
Sometimes in the university café.
Sometimes online.
At first...
our conversations were completely academic.
Research.
Presentations.
Deadlines.
Nothing more.
Slowly...
the conversations became a little longer.
She asked about India.
I asked about Australia.
She wanted to know why I always preferred
homemade food.
I laughed and explained.
I asked why Australians loved coffee so much.
She laughed and answered.
Unlike many people...

she never asked questions that made me
uncomfortable.
She never forced conversations.
She simply listened.
One evening...
after finishing our assignment...
she noticed I was unusually quiet.
"You okay?"
I smiled.
"Yeah."
She looked at me for a second.
Then quietly said,
"You don't have to answer if you don't want to."
That sentence surprised me.
She didn't insist.
She didn't become curious.
She simply respected my silence.
From that day...
our friendship slowly grew.
Not quickly.
Not dramatically.
Just...
naturally.
Sometimes...
we studied together before exams.
Sometimes...
we worked late in the library.
If one of us forgot lunch...
the other would remind them to eat.
Small things.
Ordinary things.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

The kind of friendship that develops without anyone noticing.

She slowly realised something about me.

Whenever someone asked about relationships...

I became unusually quiet.

Whenever conversations turned towards love...

I smiled...

but never spoke.

She noticed.

But she never asked why.

And I was grateful for that.

One rainy evening...

while walking back from university...

she suddenly said,

"You always take care of everyone else."

"But..."

"Who takes care of you?"

For a moment...

I didn't know what to say.

No one had ever asked me that before.

I smiled softly.

"I manage."

She smiled back.

"I know."

"But you shouldn't always have to."

That night...

I kept thinking about those words.

Not because I had fallen in love.

Far from it.

I still couldn't imagine loving anyone.

My heart still belonged to memories I had left behind in India.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Lily never tried to replace those memories.
She never competed with them.
She never even knew they existed.
She simply became someone who made difficult days
feel a little lighter.
Someone who reminded me to eat.
Someone who wished me luck before exams.
Someone who celebrated my small achievements.
Someone who made me laugh...
without even trying.
For the first time in many years...
I smiled...
without forcing myself to.
Not because I had forgotten Aashika.
But because life had quietly shown me...
that healing doesn't begin with forgetting.
It begins with allowing yourself to live again.
Nearly a year had passed.
Australia no longer felt unfamiliar.
University.
Assignments.
Part-time work.
Weekends with friends.
Video calls with my family.
That had slowly become my life.
Even though I was thousands of kilometres away...
I never stopped calling home.
Almost every night...
I spoke to my parents.
Sometimes to my sister.
Sometimes to my relatives.
Those calls made Australia feel a little less lonely.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Whenever I got semester holidays...
I tried my best to visit India.
Not for sightseeing.
Not for vacations.
Just to spend a few weeks with the people I loved.
'The moment I landed...
everything felt familiar again.
'The weather.
'The food.
'The language.
Even the noise on the roads somehow felt
comforting.
Every time I came home...
my parents became children again.
My mother cooked every dish I liked.
My father kept asking about Australia.
My sister never stopped making fun of my accent
whenever I accidentally mixed English with Tamil.
For a few weeks...
it felt like I had never left.
Sometimes...
I visited Kerala too.
Not because I expected anything to change.
Because it was still my aunt's house.
My second home.
'The house looked exactly the same.
'The sofa.
'The dining table.
'The balcony.
Everything remained where it had always been.
Only...
time had quietly changed the people inside it.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

By then...
Aashika had become busier with her work.
Sometimes she came home late.
Sometimes she worked from home.
Sometimes she spent weekends with office friends.
Our conversations were still limited to simple greetings.
Nothing more.
One evening...
everyone was having dinner together.
The conversation slowly shifted towards work.
My aunt smiled and asked,
"So... how's office?"
Aashika smiled.
"It's good."
She spoke about a few projects.
A few colleagues.
Some funny incidents.
Everyone laughed.
I listened quietly.
Then...
someone casually mentioned one particular colleague.
Not for the first time.
I had heard that name before.
But this time...
the conversation felt different.
My aunt smiled.
"So..."
"Is he the one you're always talking about?"
The entire table laughed.
Aashika became slightly embarrassed.
She smiled without saying much.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Nobody thought much about it.
The conversation moved on.
But my heart...
didn't.
That night...
I sat alone on the balcony.
Looking at the city lights.
Trying not to think about what I had heard.
The next few days...
small conversations around the house slowly
confirmed what I had already begun to understand.
She and that colleague had become very close.
They weren't just office friends anymore.
They were spending more time together.
Talking outside work.
Meeting often.
Their relationship had quietly grown.
Nobody announced it dramatically.
There wasn't a big family discussion.
Life simply moved forward.
And somewhere within that ordinary flow of life...
I realised something extraordinary.
Aashika had found someone.
For a long time...
I said nothing.
Not because I wasn't hurt.
Because I had no right to question her happiness.
That evening...
I opened our old WhatsApp chat again.
The conversation still ended with my apology.
The last message was still mine.
The last reply...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

was still silence.
I smiled faintly.
Not because it was funny.
Because I finally understood something.
That chapter of my life had ended years ago.
I had simply been the last person to accept it.
A few days later...
I returned to Australia.
Back to university.
Back to assignments.
Back to my part-time job.
Back to the life I had slowly built.
Lily noticed something.
The first day after I returned...
she found me sitting alone in the university courtyard.
Usually...
I would greet her first.
That day...
I didn't.
She quietly walked over and sat beside me.
For a few minutes...
neither of us spoke.
Then she asked,
"Home was good?"
I smiled.
"Yeah..."
"It was."
She looked at me for a second.
Then gently asked,
"But..."
"Something happened... didn't it?"
I looked at the ground.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

For the first time...
I wanted to tell someone everything.
But the words refused to come.
So I simply answered,
"I think..."
"I finally learned how to let go."
Lily didn't ask another question.
She didn't try to comfort me.
She simply sat beside me.
Sometimes...
silence shared with the right person feels lighter than
a thousand comforting words.
As the sun slowly disappeared behind the university
buildings...
I looked towards the sky.
India was thousands of kilometres away.
So was Aashika.
For the first time...
I accepted that some people remain part of your
story...
even after they stop being part of your life.
And quietly...
without telling anyone...
I decided to stop waiting for a future that had already
chosen another path.

Chapter Twenty-Nine

Her Wedding

Life in Australia continued.
Assignments.
Examinations.
Part-time work.
Weekdays slowly became months.
Months quietly became years.
I had finally learned how to live without expecting a message from her.
But...
there are some names that never leave your heart.
No matter how much time passes.
One evening...
after returning from my part-time job...
My phone suddenly vibrated.
It was my mother.
Usually...
she never called at that time.
So I answered immediately.
"Hello, Amma."
We spoke normally.
She asked whether I had eaten.
Whether I was sleeping properly.
Whether my studies were going well.
The usual questions.
Then...
after a short silence...
she said something that made my entire world stop.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"Aashika's marriage has been fixed."
For a few seconds...
I didn't hear anything after that.
My mother continued speaking.
Telling me about the engagement.
About the groom.
About the wedding date.
About the preparations.
But...
my mind had already become silent.
I don't remember how that phone call ended.
I only remember sitting on the edge of my bed.
Holding my phone.
Looking at nothing.
After all these years...
I had prepared myself for this day.
I had imagined it many times.
I had even told myself,
"One day she'll marry someone else."
But...
imagining something...
and actually hearing it...
are two completely different things.
For the first time in years...
I cried again.
Not loudly.
Not dramatically.
Exactly the same way I had cried on the bus after July
22.
Quietly.
Alone.
There was no one in my room.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

No one to ask what happened.
No one to comfort me.
Only me.
And the silence.
That night...
I couldn't eat.
The food remained untouched.
Assignments remained unfinished.
I simply lay on my bed.
Looking at the ceiling.
Memories started returning one after another.
The first train journey after lockdown.
The handmade gifts.
Late-night phone calls.
The lockdown conversations.
Her love story.
Her tears.
July 22.
Everything.
I kept asking myself one question.
"Is this really the end?"
The next morning...
Lily noticed something was wrong.
She looked at me during class.
"You don't look okay."
I smiled.
"I'm fine."
She knew I wasn't.
But just like always...
she didn't force me to explain.
That evening...
she came to my apartment with coffee.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

She placed one cup in front of me.
Then quietly sat opposite me.
After a long silence...
she softly asked,
"Someone important?"
I looked at the coffee.
Smiled faintly.
Then nodded.
"Yeah."
She didn't ask,
"Who?"
She didn't ask,
"What happened?"
She simply listened.
For the first time...
I told someone.
Not every detail.
Not the entire story.
Just enough.
I told her about a girl I had known almost my whole
life.
A girl who had unknowingly become the most
important person in my life.
A girl I never confessed to.
A girl who was now getting married.
After listening quietly...
Lily asked only one question.
"Do you still love her?"
I looked outside the window.
The answer came without thinking.
"Yes."
Another silence filled the room.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Then Lily smiled gently.
"You know..."
"Loving someone..."
"and letting them be happy..."
are sometimes the same thing."
Those words stayed with me.
Long after she had gone home.
A few days later...
my parents called again.
They wanted to know whether I would be coming to
India for the wedding.
For a long time...
I didn't answer.
Every part of me wanted to say no.
I didn't want to see her getting married.
I didn't want to stand there pretending to be happy.
I didn't want my final memory of her to be someone
else's bride.
But another part of me remembered something.
The promise I had unknowingly made years ago.
If loving her ever became a burden...
I would carry that burden alone.
I would never become one for her.
Slowly...
I picked up my phone.
Booked my flight to India for both.
Then looked at the confirmation email for a long
time.
I whispered to myself,
"If this is the last chapter of our story..."
"I want to end it by wishing her happiness."
For the first time...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I wasn't travelling to India with hope.
I was travelling...
to say goodbye.
The day finally arrived.
The day I had imagined...
and feared...
for years.
After landing in India...
I spent a few days with my family.
Everyone was busy preparing for the wedding.
The house was full of excitement.
Shopping bags.
Wedding invitations.
Phone calls.
Relatives arriving one after another.
Everything felt alive.
This time...
I wasn't coming alone.
Lily had come to India with me.
She had always wanted to visit India.
And when she heard about the wedding...
she simply asked,
"Would you like me to come with you?"
I looked at her for a few seconds.
Then nodded.
I didn't know whether I needed company.
But I knew...
I didn't want to be alone.
On the morning of the wedding...
I wore a cream-colored sherwani.
While standing in front of the mirror...
I couldn't recognize myself.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I looked older.
More mature.
Life had quietly changed me.
Lily smiled.
"You look good."
I smiled back.
"So do you."
She adjusted the collar of my sherwani.
Then softly said,
"Ready?"
I looked towards the door.
Took a deep breath.
"No."
"...But let's go."
The wedding hall was already crowded.
Cars filled the parking area.
Children were running everywhere.
Relatives greeted one another after years.
The sound of the nadaswaram echoed throughout the hall.
The entire place was overflowing with happiness.
The moment I entered...
many relatives recognized me.
"Mithran!"
"When did you come from Australia?"
"You've changed so much!"
"You've become thinner!"
Everyone surrounded me.
Asked questions.
Laughed.
Welcomed Lily warmly.

Everything looked exactly like every family function we had ever attended.

Then...

without even thinking...

I started helping.

Just like I always had.

Someone asked me to move a few chairs.

I did.

Someone needed help carrying gifts.

I carried them.

Someone wanted another table arranged.

I arranged it.

Her father looked tired.

Wedding responsibilities never end.

Without him asking...

I stood beside him.

Helping wherever I could.

Receiving guests.

Guiding relatives.

Carrying flower baskets.

Helping the decorators.

Speaking with photographers.

Taking things from one place to another.

He smiled at me.

"I knew you'd help."

I smiled back.

"Of course, Mama."

Nothing more.

For a few hours...

I kept myself busy.

Not because I loved helping.

Because stopping even for a minute...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

would force me to think.
And I wasn't ready for that.
Lily quietly watched me.
She never interrupted.
She simply helped wherever she could.
Sometimes helping my aunt.
Sometimes speaking with my sister.
She understood...
without anyone explaining.
Then...
someone called out loudly,
"The bride is coming."
Everything around me stopped.
Not outside.
Inside.
People immediately stood up.
Children rushed towards the entrance.
Phones came out.
Everyone smiled.
The photographers adjusted their cameras.
Music became louder.
Without realizing it...
I turned towards the entrance.
And then...
I saw her.
For a moment...
I forgot how to breathe.
She was wearing a traditional bridal saree.
Jewellery reflected beneath the lights.
Flowers decorated her hair.
There was a calm smile on her face.
Not the smile of the girl I knew as a child.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

The smile of a woman beginning a new life.
I didn't cry.
I couldn't.
I simply stood there...
unable to blink.
Everything around me became silent.
The music disappeared.
The conversations disappeared.
The crowd disappeared.
Only she remained.
Then...
my memories quietly began returning.
A little girl who played with me during family visits.
The first mobile phone conversations.
The lockdown.
The handmade birthday gifts.
The train journeys.
The sleepless nights.
Her telling me about her first love.
Her tears.
The phone call where I decided to hide my own
feelings forever.
Her sister's wedding.
The selfie.
Teaching her how to ride.
Playing YouKnow.
July 17.
July 22.
The bus.
The messages.
The silence.
Everything.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Every single memory.
In just a few seconds.
I realised something.
I wasn't looking at the girl I loved.
I was looking at every version of her that had ever
existed in my life.
The child.
The best friend.
The cousin.
The person who unknowingly became my first love.
And now...
the bride.
Someone gently touched my shoulder.
It was Lily.
She didn't say anything.
She simply stood beside me.
Her presence reminded me where I was.
I slowly smiled.
Not because I felt happy.
Because I had finally accepted...
this moment belonged to her.
Not to me.
A few minutes later...
our eyes met.
She smiled warmly.
The same familiar smile.
The one that had once made my entire day better.
She walked towards me.
Still smiling.
"It's been so long."
I nodded.
"It has."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

She looked at Lily.
"You must be Lily."
Lily smiled politely.
"Yes."
"It's so nice finally meeting you."
Aashika smiled.
"I'm really happy you both came."
There wasn't any awkwardness.
There wasn't any anger.
Only time.
Years had softened everything.
Then she looked back at me.
"Thank you for coming."
I smiled.
The hardest smile of my life.
"I wouldn't have missed it."
She smiled once more.
Then someone called her name.
The bride was needed on stage.
She excused herself.
And slowly walked away.
I stood there watching her.
Not because I wanted her to come back.
Because I knew...
that would be the last time I would ever see her...
before she became someone else's wife.
Around me...
everyone celebrated.
Nobody noticed the war taking place inside my heart.
Except one person.
Lily.
She quietly stood beside me.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Not saying a single word.
Because sometimes...
the greatest kindness isn't finding the right words.
It's simply staying beside someone...
when words can no longer help.
The wedding rituals slowly began.
The priest chanted mantras.
Relatives gathered around the stage.
The photographers kept asking everyone to move
closer.
Children continued running around the hall.
Everything looked exactly the way every Indian
wedding should.
Full of life.
Full of happiness.
I quietly stood among the crowd.
Not too close.
Not too far.
Just enough to see everything.
Every few minutes...
someone from the family called me.
"Mithran..."
"Can you bring that tray?"
"Mithran..."
"Can you call the photographer?"
"Mithran..."
"Can you help them carry this?"
I nodded every single time.
Keeping myself busy had become the easiest way to
stop thinking.
Her father looked relieved whenever I helped.
He smiled proudly.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

As if nothing had changed between us.
And honestly...
nothing had changed between our families.
Only between us.
The wedding continued.
Garlands were exchanged.
The hall erupted into applause.
Everyone smiled.
Phones were raised to capture the moment.
I smiled too.
Just enough for nobody to notice the difference.
Then came the final ritual.
The moment everyone had been waiting for.
The sacred thread.
The mangalsutra.
The priest gave it to the groom.
The music became louder.
The entire hall stood up.
Everyone watched with excitement.
I watched too.
Not because I wanted to.
Because I couldn't look away.
In one simple moment...
years of memories quietly came to an end.
The groom tied the mangalsutra around her neck.
The hall burst into applause.
Flowers were showered over them.
Everyone stood to bless the newly married couple.
I clapped too.
Slowly.
Quietly.
With a smile that only I knew was breaking.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

At that exact moment...
I realised something.
She wasn't becoming someone else's wife.
She had simply reached the future she was meant to have.
I was the one who had stayed behind.
For a few seconds...
I closed my eyes.
Not to stop the tears.
To thank life.
Thank you...
for letting me meet her.
Thank you...
for giving me years of memories.
Even if they were never meant to become forever.
After the ceremony...
everyone rushed onto the stage to congratulate the couple.
Family members.
Friends.
Office colleagues.
One after another.
Soon...
it was my turn.
I slowly climbed the stage.
Each step somehow felt heavier than the one before.
Aashika looked at me and smiled.
A genuine smile.
The same smile I had seen thousands of times before.
Only today...
it belonged to someone else's future.
I handed her the gift.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

She accepted it with both hands.
"Thank you..."
she said softly.
I looked at her for a few seconds.
There were so many things I had once imagined
saying.
So many conversations that never happened.
So many questions that would never have answers.
In the end...
I said only one sentence.
"I'm really happy for you."
She smiled.
"Thank you."
"I hope you stay for lunch."
I laughed softly.
"I will."
That was it.
No hidden meanings.
No unfinished confessions.
No dramatic goodbye.
Just two people...
who had once been an important part of each other's
lives...
speaking like ordinary relatives.
Before leaving the stage...
I looked once at the groom.
He smiled respectfully.
I smiled back.
There was no hatred.
No jealousy anymore.
Only acceptance.
If she had chosen him...

then I silently wished that he would give her the
happiness I couldn't.
The rest of the afternoon passed in a blur.
People kept talking.
Laughing.
Taking photographs.
Calling everyone for group pictures.
I stood wherever someone asked me to stand.
Smiled whenever the camera pointed towards me.
Nobody noticed anything unusual.
Only Lily did.
Every time she looked at me...
she knew I was pretending.
But she respected that decision.
She never tried to stop me.
She never tried to pull me away.
She simply stayed close.
Quietly.
As evening approached...
the wedding slowly came to an end.
Guests started leaving.
The decorations were being removed.
The musicians packed their instruments.
Children who had been running around all day finally
became tired.
The hall slowly became empty.
I stepped outside.
For the first time since morning.
The evening breeze felt colder than usual.
The noise from inside the hall slowly faded behind
me.
I walked towards the parking area.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

No destination.
No reason.
I simply kept walking.
Until nobody else was around.
Only then...
I stopped.
For the first time that entire day...
I allowed myself to cry.
Not loudly.
Not the way I had cried after July 22.
These tears were different.
Calmer.
Quieter.
Almost peaceful.
There was no anger left.
No questions left.
No expectations left.
Only gratitude.
And goodbye.
I wiped my tears with my sleeve.
Took one deep breath.
Then slowly turned around.
From where I stood...
I could still see the entrance of the wedding hall.
People were still smiling.
Photographs were still being taken.
Somewhere inside...
Aashika was beginning a new chapter of her life.
I smiled.
A real smile this time.
Small.
But real.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Very softly...
so softly that even I could barely hear it...
I whispered,
"Be happy..."
"That's all I ever wanted for you."
I didn't wait for another look.
I didn't wait for another goodbye.
I didn't look back again.
Some endings don't need one last glance.
They only need the courage to keep walking.
As I walked away...
I realised something.
I hadn't stopped loving her.
I had simply stopped holding on.
And perhaps...
that is what letting go truly means.

Chapter Thirty

Never Like This

A year passed after Aashika's wedding.
Life quietly continued.
Whether I was ready or not...
time never stopped moving.
I returned to Australia.
The same airport.
The same apartment.
The same university.
But...
something inside me had changed.
For the first time in many years...
my heart wasn't waiting for a message anymore.
The pain didn't disappear.
It simply became quieter.
Some days I remembered her.
Some days I didn't.
Some nights I smiled at old memories.
Some nights I simply slept.
Healing wasn't something that happened overnight.
It happened one ordinary day at a time.
University life became busier.
My Master's degree demanded more time than before.
Research papers.
Presentations.
Projects.
Late-night assignments.
Part-time work.

Days disappeared before I even noticed.
Lily remained beside me.
Not because she tried to.
Because life naturally kept bringing us together.
We still studied together.
Worked on projects together.
Prepared for examinations together.
Whenever I became stressed...
she somehow noticed before I said anything.
Whenever she had problems...
she called me first.
Without planning it...
we had become part of each other's daily routine.
Some weekends...
we explored new places around the city.
Coffee shops.
Bookstores.
Museums.
Parks.
Nothing that looked like a date.
Just two friends...
trying to enjoy life outside university.
One day...
while walking through a weekend market...
Lily suddenly laughed.
"What?"
I asked.
She pointed towards a small handmade keychain.
"It looks exactly like something you'd make."
I laughed.
"Why?"
"Because it's simple."

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"But someone clearly spent a lot of time making it."
For a second...
I remembered the gifts I had once made for Aashika.
Then...
I quietly smiled.
"Maybe."
Lily noticed my smile.
She didn't ask why.
She had learned that some smiles belonged to
memories.
Months became another year.
Our friendship quietly became stronger.
Without promises.
Without expectations.
Without trying to become anything else.
She met my parents during video calls.
My mother immediately liked her.
My father often asked,
"Is Lily helping you with your studies?"
I laughed.
"Sometimes."
Lily smiled from the other side of the screen.
"Aunty..."
"He helps me more."
Everyone laughed.
Slowly...
our families came to know about each other.
Not because we announced anything.
Because our friendship had naturally become part of
our lives.
One evening...
after submitting our final project...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

we sat outside the university.
Watching the sunset.
Just like we had done many times before.
Lily quietly asked,
"Can I ask you something?"
"Hmm."
"Do you still think about her?"
I smiled.
Honestly.
"Sometimes."
She nodded.
"I thought so."
"I don't compare you with her."
I continued.
"I never will."
"Because..."
"There will never be another Aashika."
Lily smiled gently.
"I know."
"And..."
"I'm not trying to become her."
That answer stayed with me.
Because it was exactly what I needed to hear.
She never wanted to replace my past.
She simply wanted to be part of my future.
Years earlier...
I had believed loving again meant forgetting my first
love.
Lily quietly taught me something different.
Love doesn't replace love.
It simply creates another place inside your heart.
Our friendship slowly became something deeper.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Not suddenly.
Not dramatically.
No grand confession.
No movie-like proposal.
Just years of trust.
Understanding.
Respect.
Care.
One evening...
while walking back from university...
I stopped.
Looked at her.
And smiled.
"I think..."
"I've finally learned how to smile again."
She smiled back.
"I know."
A few months later...
after speaking with both our families...
we decided to get married.
Not because we completed each other.
But because...
we had already spent years walking beside each other.
And neither of us wanted to walk alone anymore.
Looking back...
I realised something.
Lily never healed me.
No one could.
She simply stayed beside me...
while I healed myself.
And sometimes...
that is the greatest form of love.

Life never stopped after our marriage.
It simply became...
different.
For the first time in many years...
I woke up every morning without carrying yesterday's
pain.
Australia had slowly become home.
Not because India meant less.
But because life had given me another place to
belong.
Lily and I built our life together...
one ordinary day at a time.
There were no fairy tales.
No perfect moments.
Just two people...
trying to make each other's lives a little easier.
Some mornings...
she made breakfast before I woke up.
Some mornings...
I made coffee before she left for work.
Sometimes we cooked together.
Sometimes we ordered food because both of us were
too tired.
Sometimes...
we laughed over the smallest mistakes.
Life had become peaceful.
We still argued occasionally.
Over small things.
Who forgot to buy groceries.
Who left the lights on.
Who worked too much.
But unlike before...

those arguments always ended the same way.
One of us apologised.
The other smiled.
And the next morning...
everything became normal again.
One evening...
while we were cleaning our apartment...
Lily found an old notebook.
She smiled.
"You still write?"
I nodded.
"Sometimes."
She handed it back without opening it.
She never read anything unless I asked her to.
That simple respect...
made me value her even more.
Months quietly became years.
Careers grew.
Responsibilities increased.
Life moved forward exactly as it always does.
Without asking whether we were ready.
Back in India...
life was also moving forward.
Whenever my mother called...
she occasionally spoke about relatives.
Family gatherings.
Festivals.
Children being born.
People moving to different cities.
Life never waited for anyone.
Sometimes...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Aashika's name came up naturally during conversations.

Not often.

Just occasionally.

"She and her husband visited last week."

"They've shifted to another house."

"They're doing well."

Every time I heard those words...

I smiled.

Genuinely.

There was a time...

when hearing her name would've ruined my entire day.

Now...

it simply reminded me of someone who had once been an important part of my life.

Nothing more.

Nothing less.

I never asked for photographs.

I never searched for her on social media.

I never tried to know more than what life naturally told me.

Some chapters deserve to remain closed.

Not because they are painful.

Because they are complete.

One night...

while sitting on our balcony...

Lily quietly asked,

"Do you regret anything?"

I looked towards the sky.

Thought for a while.

Then answered honestly.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"I regret my decision."
She looked at me.
I continued.
"But..."
"I don't regret loving her."
Lily gently held my hand.
Not to erase my past.
Just to remind me that she was here.
I smiled.
"Thank you."
"For what?"
"For never asking me to forget."
She smiled softly.
"If I asked you to forget..."
"I'd be asking you to erase a part of who you are."
"I fell in love with the man you became."
"Not with the pain you carried."
For a moment...
I couldn't speak.
Because after everything life had taught me...
I finally understood something.
Real love never competes with old memories.
It simply creates new ones.
Thousands of kilometres away...
Aashika was living her own life.
She had a loving husband.
A home.
A future she had chosen.
I had mine too.
We no longer shared the same road.
But once...
our paths had crossed.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

And that was enough.
Neither of us had failed.
Neither of us had won.
Life had simply written two different endings.
To the same beginning.
Years passed.
Life became peaceful.
Not perfect.
Just...
peaceful.
I was thirty years old now.
Life looked completely different from the way I had
imagined it when I was twenty.
Back then...
I thought happiness meant ending up with the person
you loved.
Now...
I understood something different.
Sometimes...
happiness is simply learning to smile again.

Chapter Thirty-One

Building a New Life

Marriage didn't change my life overnight.
There was no magical feeling the next morning.
No sudden realization that everything had become perfect.
Life simply...
continued.
Only this time...
I wasn't living alone anymore.
Australia had already become familiar.
The roads no longer felt confusing.
The cold mornings had become normal.
Even the strong Australian accent that once made every conversation difficult had slowly become something I understood.
But there was one thing I had never experienced before.
Coming home...
and knowing someone was already there.
Lily had moved into our apartment a week after the wedding.
It wasn't a large apartment.
Just a simple two-bedroom home on the third floor of a quiet building.
There was a small balcony overlooking the street.
A tiny kitchen.
A living room with a grey sofa.

And a dining table that was honestly too big for just
the two of us.
But somehow...
it already felt like home.
The first morning after we settled in...
I woke up before sunrise.
Old habits never changed.
Back in India...
my mother used to wake up early every day.
Even after moving to Australia...
my body still followed the same routine.
I quietly walked into the kitchen.
The house was completely silent.
The only sound came from the refrigerator humming
softly.
I opened the cupboard.
Coffee.
Sugar.
Milk.
Everything was exactly where Lily had arranged it.
I smiled.
Just as I switched on the kettle...
I heard a sleepy voice behind me.
"What are you doing?"
I turned around.
Lily stood there with messy hair, still half asleep.
"Weren't you sleeping?"
I asked.
"I was..."
"...until someone started making enough noise to
wake the whole building."
I laughed.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"I only switched on the kettle."
She smiled.
"I know."
"I'm just blaming you because I'm awake now."
That was our first married argument.
About a kettle.
Five minutes later...
we were sitting on the balcony with two cups of
coffee.
Neither of us spoke much.
We simply watched people walking to work.
Cars passing.
Birds flying across the morning sky.
The silence wasn't awkward.
It was comfortable.
Lily suddenly looked at me.
"What?"
I asked.
She smiled.
"I still can't believe we're married."
I looked at the ring on my finger.
Then at hers.
Neither could I.
Some things in life don't feel real immediately.
They slowly become reality...
one ordinary day at a time.
Our weekdays quickly found a rhythm.
Every morning...
I left for work before eight.
Lily usually left thirty minutes later.
Whoever returned home first...
started preparing dinner.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

That was our unspoken agreement.
No schedule.
No discussion.
It just happened naturally.
The first week...
I decided to surprise her by cooking.
I called my mother.
"Amma..."
"How do I make sambar?"
She laughed immediately.
"Finally."
"I was waiting for this call."
For almost forty minutes...
she patiently explained every step.
How much tamarind.
How much salt.
When to add the vegetables.
When to switch off the stove.
I carefully followed every instruction.
Or at least...
I thought I did.
When Lily came home...
the entire apartment smelled like burnt curry leaves.
She looked at me.
Then at the kitchen.
Then back at me.
"What happened here?"
I scratched my head.
"I followed the recipe."
She looked inside the vessel.
"I think..."
"...the recipe stopped following you."

We both laughed so hard that evening...
we ended up ordering pizza instead.
The untouched sambar quietly remained on the stove.
Neither of us mentioned it again.
The next Sunday...
she stood beside me.
"This time..."
"I'm teaching."
And together...
we cooked.
Slowly.
Carefully.
Correctly.
That meal tasted far better.
Not because of the recipe.
Because we had made it together.
Every evening...
without fail...
I called my parents.
Some days it lasted five minutes.
Some days nearly an hour.
My mother always asked the same questions.
"Did you eat?"
"Are you sleeping properly?"
"Is Lily taking care of you?"
Before I could answer...
Lily would shout from the kitchen,
"He's eating too much, Aunty!"
My mother laughed.
"So nothing has changed."
Life slowly became filled with these tiny moments.
Buying groceries together.

Arguing over which cereal to buy.
Forgetting milk.
Going back to the supermarket because we forgot milk.
Then forgetting bread.
Returning again.
One Saturday...
we decided to buy furniture.
The apartment still looked empty.
Only the essentials were there.
A bed.
A dining table.
A sofa.
Nothing more.
We spent nearly four hours inside IKEA.
Lily wanted everything.
Plants.
Lamps.
Wall paintings.
Decorations.
Pillows.
More pillows.
Even more pillows.
I looked at the trolley.
"Lily..."
"We're decorating a house."
"Not opening a furniture showroom."
She folded her arms.
"It's called making a home."
I looked around.
"There are already twelve cushions."
She smiled proudly.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"Exactly."
By the end of the day...
the car was so full...
I couldn't even see through the rear window.
That evening...
we spent hours assembling furniture.
The instruction manual looked simple.
Reality...
wasn't.
At one point...
we realised we had attached the bookshelf upside
down.
We stared at it for almost a minute.
Then both started laughing.
We dismantled everything.
And started again.
The apartment slowly changed.
Photographs appeared on the walls.
Small plants on the balcony.
Books on the shelves.
A family calendar near the kitchen.
Magnets collected from different cities.
Tiny things.
But together...
they transformed four walls into a home.
Sometimes...
late at night...
after finishing work...
I stood alone on the balcony.
Looking at the lights of the city.
The cool Australian wind brushing past.
There were moments...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

when I missed India.
The festivals.
The noise.
Street food.
Relatives dropping in without calling.
Speaking Tamil everywhere.
The smell of rain on hot roads.
Those things never truly leave you.
No matter how long you live abroad.
One evening...
Lily quietly walked onto the balcony carrying two
cups of juice.
She handed one to me.
Then asked,
"Missing home?"
I nodded.
"A little."
She looked at the night sky.
Then softly replied,
"We'll visit soon."
No big speech.
No attempt to make me feel better.
Just one sentence.
Simple.
Honest.
Enough.
As I looked around our little apartment...
I realised something.
Home wasn't one place anymore.
Part of it would always remain in India.
Another part...
had quietly begun here.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Thousands of kilometres away.
In a small apartment.
With someone who never tried to replace my past...
but patiently helped me build a future.
The first few months passed faster than I expected.
Monday became Friday.
Friday became another Monday.
Before I realised it...
three months had already gone by.
Life slowly found its rhythm.
Wake up.
Go to work.
Come back home.
Cook dinner.
Watch something together.
Call our families.
Sleep.
Then begin again.
It wasn't exciting.
It wasn't adventurous.
It was simply...
life.
And strangely...
I liked it.
Every Sunday evening became special.
No matter how busy we were...
we never skipped the family video call.
At exactly seven-thirty in the evening Australian
time...
my phone would ring.
"Amma Calling..."
The moment I answered...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

the screen was already filled with familiar faces.
My parents.
My sister.
Sometimes my aunt.
Sometimes my uncle.
Occasionally...
Aashika's family joined too.
Everyone spoke at the same time.
No one listened.
Exactly like every Indian family call.
"Have you eaten?"
"How's work?"
"When are you coming to India?"
"Show us the apartment."
"Where's Lily?"
Questions never stopped.
Lily would quietly walk into the frame carrying her coffee.
The moment my mother saw her...
she smiled.
"Lily... are you feeding him properly?"
Lily looked at me.
Then at my mother.
She laughed.
"Aunty..."
"I'm trying."
"But he still eats Maggi whenever I'm not home."
"Eh!"
I protested.
"I cooked yesterday."
Lily folded her arms.
"Yes."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"You cooked."
"And then you called me because you forgot to switch off the stove."
The entire family burst into laughter.
Even I couldn't defend myself.
Those calls never lasted less than an hour.
Sometimes...
we didn't even have anything important to talk about.
Yet...
nobody wanted to disconnect.
After every call...
the apartment felt strangely quiet.
I would sit on the sofa for a few minutes.
Looking at the blank phone screen.
Thinking about home.
Lily noticed that habit.
One evening she asked,
"You miss them a lot, don't you?"
I nodded.
"I do."
She smiled gently.
"Good."
I looked at her.
"Good?"
She nodded.
"People who miss home..."
"never forget where they came from."
I never forgot those words.
Winter arrived.
For the first time...
Lily convinced me to buy a proper winter jacket.
I looked at the price tag.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Immediately placed it back.
"This costs too much."
She rolled her eyes.
"You've lived here for years."
"And you're still pretending one hoodie is enough."
"I survived last winter."
"You survived."
"You didn't live."
Half an hour later...
I walked out of the store wearing the exact jacket she
had chosen.
Sometimes...
love looked like expensive jackets.
Work became busier.
My company assigned me to a new project.
Deadlines became tighter.
Meetings became longer.
Many nights...
I returned home after eight.
Exhausted.
Every time...
the apartment lights were already on.
Dinner was ready.
Lily would look up from the dining table.
"Long day?"
I nodded.
She didn't ask anything else.
She simply served dinner.
Some days...
silence was more comforting than conversation.
There were evenings when she had difficult days too.
She worked just as hard as I did.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Sometimes harder.
Whenever she looked tired...
I made tea.
Terrible tea.
But tea nonetheless.
One night...
she tasted it.
Made a strange face.
"What?"
I asked.
She smiled.
"I think..."
"...you've somehow managed to burn hot water."
I laughed so loudly that even she started laughing.
Those little moments slowly became our favourite
memories.
Not vacations.
Not celebrations.
Just...
ordinary evenings.
December arrived.
Which meant...
our first Christmas together.
Neither of us celebrated Christmas traditionally.
Still...
Lily insisted on buying a small Christmas tree.
"It'll make the apartment look nice."
She was right.
We spent an entire evening decorating it.
Tiny lights.
Small ornaments.
A little star at the top.

When everything was finally finished...
we switched off the lights.
Only the tree remained glowing.
"It looks beautiful."
I whispered.
Lily smiled.
"Next year..."
"We'll decorate a bigger one."
I didn't know then...
how quickly "next year" would arrive.
A few weeks later...
Pongal came.
For the first time in my life...
I celebrated Pongal outside India.
It felt strange.
No sugarcane.
No kolam outside the house.
No neighbours visiting.
No loud celebrations.
Early that morning...
I called my parents.
The camera showed our house.
Fresh kolam.
Banana leaves.
The smell of sakkarai pongal almost reached me
through the screen.
My mother smiled.
"You should've been here."
I smiled too.
"I know."
After the call ended...
I quietly stood near the balcony.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Watching the empty street below.
For the first time that day...
I genuinely felt lonely.
Without saying anything...
Lily disappeared into the kitchen.
Twenty minutes later...
she called me.
"Close your eyes."
"What?"
"Just do it."
I closed my eyes.
She guided me to the dining table.
"Okay..."
"Open."
I slowly opened my eyes.
There...
on the table...
was a small bowl of sakkarai pongal.
Not perfect.
Not exactly like my mother's.
But close.
Very close.
"You..."
"How?"
She smiled proudly.
"I called your mother yesterday."
"She taught me."
For a few seconds...
I couldn't speak.
I took one spoon.
Tasted it.
Looked at Lily.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Then quietly smiled.
"It tastes like home."
She didn't reply.
She simply smiled.
Because sometimes...
that's all love needs to do.
It doesn't replace home.
It brings a small part of it to you.
That night...
before sleeping...
I realised something.
Australia no longer felt like a country where I lived.
It had slowly become...
the place where I was building a life.
One ordinary day at a time.
Nearly a year had passed.
Without either of us realizing it...
our apartment had slowly transformed into a home.
The empty walls now held photographs.
The bookshelves were no longer empty.
The balcony was filled with small plants that Lily
insisted on buying every weekend.
Some had already dried because I kept forgetting to
water them.
Every Sunday...
she reminded me.
Every Sunday...
I forgot again.
One evening...
after returning from work...
I unlocked the apartment door.
Before I could even place my bag down...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I heard Lily calling from the kitchen.
"Mithran?"
"Hmm?"
"Can you taste this?"
I walked over.
She handed me a spoon.
"What is it?"
"Just taste."
I took one bite.
Paused.
Looked at her.
She immediately became nervous.
"Bad?"
I smiled.
"No."
"It's actually good."
She sighed dramatically.
"Oh thank God."
"I thought your mother was going to disown me."
I laughed.
"My mother would probably ask you to teach me instead."
Dinner had become our favourite part of the day.
No phones.
No television.
Just the two of us talking about work.
Sometimes about family.
Sometimes about absolutely nothing.
That night...
my phone buzzed.
Family
The WhatsApp group.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Almost two hundred unread messages.
I smiled.
Nothing had changed.
Indian families could turn a simple "Good Morning"
into a hundred-message conversation.
I opened the chat.
My aunt had sent photographs.
There had been a small family get-together back in
Kerala.
Everyone was there.
My parents.
My sister.
My uncle.
My aunt.
A few cousins.
And...
Aashika.
Standing beside her husband.
Both smiling at the camera.
I stared at the photograph for a few seconds.
Not because I was sad.
Not because I was jealous.
Because...
for a moment...
I wished I had been there too.
Lily walked over with a cup of tea.
She noticed the smile on my face.
"Family?"
I nodded.
"They all met today."
She sat beside me.
"Looks fun."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"It does."

She looked at the screen for a second.

Then smiled.

"You should call them."

Without thinking much...

I pressed the video call button.

Within seconds...

everyone appeared on the screen.

The camera kept moving because nobody knew who was actually holding the phone.

"Mithraaaaaan!"

My aunt shouted.

"When did you wake up?"

I laughed.

"It's evening here, Athai."

"Oh."

She looked embarrassed.

"I forgot."

Everyone laughed.

My father immediately asked,

"How's work?"

Before I could answer...

my mother interrupted.

"Leave work."

"Tell me whether you're eating properly."

"I'm eating, Amma."

"Show your face properly."

"You look thinner."

"I've literally gained two kilos."

"Still..."

"You look thin."

Some things never change.

No matter which country you're living in.

The phone suddenly changed hands.

Now it was my sister.

She grinned.

"So..."

"When are you coming to India?"

"Soon."

"You've been saying 'soon' for six months."

"I know."

Behind her...

someone suddenly leaned into the camera.

Aashika.

She smiled.

"Australia has changed you."

I laughed.

"No."

"I'm still the same idiot."

She nodded immediately.

"That part definitely hasn't changed."

The entire room burst into laughter.

Even Lily couldn't stop laughing.

For the next thirty minutes...

everyone spoke over each other.

Nobody listened.

Stories jumped from one topic to another.

Someone talked about a neighbour.

Someone complained about traffic.

Someone asked about Australian weather.

Someone wanted chocolates.

Another wanted a new phone.

It was complete chaos.

Exactly the kind of chaos I had missed.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Before ending the call...
my uncle smiled.
"Come home soon."
My aunt nodded.
"The house feels incomplete without you."
"I'll come."
I promised.
"And this time..."
"I'll stay longer."
The call ended.
The apartment became quiet again.
For a few minutes...
I continued looking at the blank screen.
Lily gently placed her hand on mine.
"You miss them."
I smiled.
"I do."
"Especially India?"
I shook my head.
"Not India."
She looked curious.
"Then?"
I thought for a moment., Then answered honestly.
"I miss..."
"...belonging somewhere without checking the
calendar."
She understood immediately.
No explanation was needed.
That night...
before sleeping...
I opened the family photograph again.
Everyone looked happy.

Parents growing older.
Children growing up.
New faces entering the family.
Old memories becoming stories.
Life hadn't stopped for anyone.
Not for me, Not for Aashika, Not for our families.
It had simply continued...
exactly the way life always does.
Quietly. Patiently.
Without asking whether we were ready.
I smiled.
Locked my phone.
Switched off the bedside lamp.
And before closing my eyes...
one thought quietly crossed my mind.
"I'm glad..."
"...we never became strangers."
Outside...
the rain had just begun.
Inside...
our little apartment finally felt like home.

Chapter Thirty-Two

Time Doesn't Ask Permission

The second year of our marriage arrived quietly.
There were no celebrations.
No countdowns.
No dramatic moments.
One morning...
I simply looked at the calendar.
And realised...
another year had already passed.
Life had become predictable.
Wake up.
Go to work.
Come home.
Cook dinner.
Watch a movie.
Sleep.
Repeat.
Years ago...
I would've called that boring.
Now...
I called it peace.
Australia had finally started feeling less like a
country...
and more like home.
I knew which supermarket had the cheapest
vegetables.
Which café made the strongest coffee.
Which road to avoid during rush hour.

Even the old cashier at the grocery store smiled whenever we entered.

"Good evening!"

he greeted.

"Back again?"

Lily laughed.

"We keep eating."

He nodded dramatically.

"I can see that."

I looked at Lily.

"I think he was talking about you."

She elbowed my arm.

"No..."

"He definitely meant you."

Our weekends slowly became my favourite part of the week.

No alarms.

No meetings.

No deadlines.

Just...

time.

Sometimes...

we drove aimlessly.

No destination.

Just music playing softly inside the car.

Windows slightly open.

Cold Australian air filling the silence between us.

Lily loved driving.

I loved watching the scenery.

It became our unspoken tradition.

Every Saturday afternoon...

we simply picked a road.

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And followed it.
One weekend...
we stopped near a small lake.
The water was perfectly still.
Children were feeding ducks.
Old couples walked hand in hand.
A man sat alone reading a book.
Life looked...
slow.
We found an empty bench.
Sat down.
Neither of us spoke.
After a few minutes...
Lily suddenly asked,
"What are you thinking?"
I looked at the lake.
Then smiled.
"Nothing."
She laughed.
"Liar."
"No really."
"I've finally reached the age..."
"...where sitting quietly feels productive."
She burst into laughter.
"You're becoming old."
"I'm thirty-one."
"Exactly."
That evening...
we returned home carrying nothing.
No shopping bags.
No souvenirs.
Just...

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another peaceful memory.
Work had also changed.
The fresh graduate who once nervously attended
meetings...
had slowly disappeared.
New employees had joined.
Some of them were younger than me.
They now came to my desk asking questions.
Exactly the way I once asked others.
One afternoon...
a new intern approached me.
"Excuse me..."
"I'm stuck."
I smiled.
"So was I..."
"...three years ago."
I spent nearly an hour helping him.
As he walked away...
I suddenly remembered someone.
My college self.
Always confused.
Always asking doubts.
Always believing adulthood would be simple.
I laughed quietly.
If only that version of me knew.
That night...
while cleaning an old drawer...
I found my Australian student ID card.
The photograph made me laugh.
My hair looked terrible.
I showed it to Lily.
She stared for a few seconds.

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Then started laughing uncontrollably.
"You looked like that?"
"I thought you married me because of this face."
She shook her head.
"No."
"I married you despite it."
We laughed until our stomachs hurt.
Later that night...
I received a message.
From my college friends.
A reunion.
Online.
Saturday night.
When the video call started...
nothing had changed.
Within two minutes...
everyone was insulting each other exactly the way we
used to.
Someone had become a software engineer.
Someone started a business.
Someone was preparing for government exams.
Someone had already become a father.
One of them suddenly looked at me.
"Machi..."
"When are you coming back to India permanently?"
I smiled.
"I don't know."
Another friend immediately said,
"You've become Australian now."
I laughed.
"No."
"My passport May change one day."

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"But my heart never will."
Everyone went silent for a second.
Then somebody shouted,
"Dei..."
"Stop talking like a movie hero."
The entire call exploded into laughter.
Those friendships...
had changed too.
We no longer spoke every day.
Sometimes not even every month.
But whenever we met...
time disappeared.
After the call ended...
I stood on the balcony.
The city lights stretched endlessly before me.
There was a time...
I used to stand here thinking about everything I had
lost.
Now...
I found myself thinking about everything I had built.
Not because one mattered more than the other.
Because life had quietly made room for both.
Inside the apartment...
Lily was already asleep.
A book rested on her chest.
The bedside lamp was still on.
I smiled.
Closed the book carefully.
Placed it on the table.
Switched off the light.
Pulled the blanket over her.
She opened one eye.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Half asleep.
"You home?"
I laughed softly.
"I never left."
She smiled without opening her eyes.
"Good..."
Then immediately fell asleep again.
Standing there...
watching someone sleep peacefully...
I realised something strange.
Love didn't always arrive with fireworks.
Sometimes...
it arrived quietly.
Like switching off a lamp.
Covering someone with a blanket.
Or making sure they didn't fall asleep waiting for you.
Outside...
another year had already begun.
Without asking permission.
Without making an announcement.
Time simply...
kept moving.
And somehow...
so did we.
The years that followed were never marked by
extraordinary moments.
Nobody woke up one morning and realised life had
become beautiful.
It happened slowly.
So slowly...
that neither of us noticed.
Every morning...

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our alarm rang at exactly 6:15.

The first battle of the day wasn't work.

It was deciding who would get out of bed first.

"You go."

Lily mumbled one morning, pulling the blanket over her face.

"I made breakfast yesterday."

I looked at her.

"I washed the dishes."

"You left one spoon."

"I left it for artistic decoration."

She laughed from beneath the blanket.

"I married an idiot."

Some mornings...

we both overslept.

Those mornings became complete chaos.

One of us searched for car keys.

The other looked for socks.

Coffee was forgotten.

Breakfast became biscuits grabbed from the kitchen counter.

As we hurried out of the apartment...

Lily suddenly stopped.

"What?"

I asked impatiently.

She smiled.

"You forgot your lunch."

I looked at the lunch box still sitting on the dining table.

She quietly placed it into my hands.

"If I wasn't here..."

"You'd probably survive on coffee."

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She wasn't wrong.
Work became more demanding with every passing
year.
I had been promoted twice.
More responsibilities.
More meetings.
More late evenings.
Sometimes...
I returned home so tired that I barely spoke.
Lily never complained.
She simply understood.
Whenever she noticed those long days...
she never asked,
"What happened?"
Instead...
she would quietly place a cup of tea beside me.
'Then continue reading her book.
Giving me space.
After twenty minutes...
she would casually ask,
"Feel better?"
Most of the time...
I simply nodded.
'That was enough.
I slowly realised something.
'There are people who solve your problems.
And then...
there are people who simply make those problems
feel lighter.
Lily belonged to the second kind.
One rainy Friday...
our company announced promotions.

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I had become Team Lead.
For a few seconds...
I simply stared at the email.
Years ago...
I had been an intern.
Scared to speak during meetings.
Now...
people looked to me for answers.
That evening...
I reached home carrying a small cake.
Lily opened the door.
She immediately noticed my smile.
"What happened?"
Without saying anything...
I handed her the cake box.
She looked confused.
"Whose birthday?"
I smiled.
"Nobody's."
"Then?"
"I got promoted."
Her eyes widened.
Before I could say anything else...
she hugged me tightly.
"I'm so proud of you."
Those four words...
meant more than the promotion itself.
That night...
we video-called my parents.
My mother clapped happily.
My father tried to hide his smile.
My sister immediately asked,

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"So..."

"Treat?"

I laughed.

"Even from another continent?"

She nodded confidently.

"Money transfer exists."

The family laughed together.

After the call ended...

I stood quietly near the balcony.

Watching the rain fall across the city.

Lily walked beside me.

"What are you thinking now?"

I smiled.

"Do you remember..."

"...when I first came to Australia?"

She nodded.

"You called home almost every day."

"I cried too."

She looked at me.

"I know."

"I never thought I'd stay this long."

She looked towards the skyline.

"Neither did I."

Sometimes...

life writes plans we never imagined.

Months later...

we finally decided to buy our own apartment.

Not because renting was difficult.

Because...

for the first time...

we wanted something that truly belonged to us.

House hunting turned out to be much harder than expected.

One apartment was too expensive.

Another had no sunlight.

Another looked beautiful in photographs...
and terrible in reality.

Every weekend...

we visited open houses.

Slowly...

our conversations changed.

Instead of asking,

"What should we do tomorrow?"

We asked,

"Can you imagine us living here?"

One afternoon...

we entered a small apartment overlooking a park.

Children were playing outside.

A gentle breeze entered through the balcony.

Sunlight filled the living room.

Lily looked around quietly.

Then looked at me.

Without speaking...

I already knew.

This was the one.

Weeks later...

after endless paperwork...

the keys finally rested in my hand.

I unlocked the front door.

We stepped inside.

The apartment was completely empty.

No furniture.

No curtains.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Only silence.
Lily slowly walked into the middle of the living room.
She stretched both arms.
Smiled.
Then looked at me.
"Welcome home."
I looked around.
The walls were bare.
The rooms echoed.
Nothing had been arranged yet.
And still...
for the first time since leaving India...
I truly felt...
I had another place I could call home.
That evening...
instead of ordering food...
we sat on the floor.
Pizza box between us.
Paper cups filled with soft drinks.
No dining table.
No sofa.
Nothing.
Yet...
I don't think any expensive restaurant could have
made us happier than that empty apartment.
While eating...
Lily suddenly laughed.
"What?"
I asked.
She pointed at the pizza box.
"Our first dinner in our own home."
I smiled.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"Very healthy."
She rolled her eyes.
"We'll start eating healthy tomorrow."
We both knew...
tomorrow would never come.
Outside...
the sun slowly disappeared behind the buildings.
Inside...
two ordinary people quietly built an ordinary life.
Brick by brick.
Meal by meal.
Memory by memory.
Without ever realising...
that these ordinary days would one day become the
memories they treasured most.
The years never announced their arrival.
There were no countdowns.
No celebrations.
No warnings.
One calendar replaced another.
One birthday followed the next.
Before we realised it...
another two years had quietly slipped away.
Our apartment no longer looked new.
The once empty walls were now filled with
photographs.
Our wedding.
Weekend trips.
Parents visiting Australia.
Friends from work.
Tiny magnets from every city we had travelled to.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

The house had slowly become a collection of moments.

Every Sunday morning...

Lily watered the plants on the balcony.

Most of them were still alive.

Which surprised both of us.

"You've become good at this."

I said one morning.

She looked at me proudly.

"I learnt."

She pointed at one tiny plant.

"You almost killed this one."

"I was experimenting."

"You forgot to water it."

"I was conducting scientific research."

She laughed.

"You should never become a scientist."

Life had become filled with conversations like that.

Simple.

Pointless.

Comfortable.

Sometimes...

I wondered if happiness had always looked this ordinary.

Maybe I had just been too busy searching for something bigger to notice it.

One evening...

my phone rang.

It was Amma.

"Hello?"

"Mithra..."

"We're thinking of coming to Australia next month."

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

For a second...
I couldn't believe what I heard.
"Really?"
She laughed.
"Yes."
"Your father finally agreed."
For the next month...
our apartment became a construction site.
Not because anything was broken.
Because Amma was coming.
Lily cleaned places I didn't even know existed.
Curtains were washed.
Cupboards were rearranged.
The guest room was prepared.
Even the spice containers were labelled neatly.
I watched all this and smiled.
"You know..."
"My mother is coming to visit."
"Not the Prime Minister."
Lily looked at me without stopping her work.
"I know."
"Which is exactly why everything has to be perfect."
The day finally arrived.
Standing at the airport...
I felt like a little boy again.
Every few seconds...
I looked towards the arrival gate.
Then...
I saw them.
My father.
Walking a little slower than I remembered.
My mother.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Still smiling the same way she always had.
I ran towards them.
For a few seconds...
none of us spoke.
Amma simply held my face with both hands.
"You've become thinner."
I laughed.
"Again?"
Appa smiled.
"She says that every time."
When we reached home...
my parents looked around the apartment.
Amma slowly walked into the kitchen.
She opened the cupboards.
Looked inside.
Closed them again.
Then she turned towards Lily.
"You've taken good care of him."
Lily smiled.
"I tried."
Amma shook her head.
"No."
"You've done more than that."
"You've given him another home."
Lily didn't know what to say.
She simply smiled.
Those two weeks disappeared too quickly.
Appa spent most evenings sitting on the balcony.
Watching the road below.
He rarely spoke.
One evening...
I joined him.

Neither of us said anything for a long time.
Finally...
he spoke.
"You've grown up."
I smiled.
"I've been grown up for years."
He shook his head.
"No."
"You've become responsible."
"That's different."
His words stayed with me.
Before leaving Australia...
Amma quietly entered our bedroom.
She placed something inside the cupboard.
After they left...
I opened it.
Inside...
were homemade spice powders.
Pickles.
Murukku.
Mysore Pak.
Everything she knew I loved.
At the bottom...
there was a handwritten note.
"No matter how old you become..."
"You'll always be the little boy who asked me to wake
him five more minutes later."
"Take care of yourself."
— Amma
I folded the note carefully.
Placed it inside the drawer.
Not because it was valuable.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Because it was priceless.
Months later...
our family WhatsApp group became active again.
This time...
because of another reason.
A photograph appeared.
Aashika and her husband.
Standing outside a hospital.
Both smiling.
The caption read:
"We're going to be parents "
The group exploded.
Congratulations.
Blessings.
Heart emojis.
Voice notes.
Everyone talking at once.
I smiled.
Without thinking...
I typed.
Congratulations.
The little one is lucky to have both of you.
A few seconds later...
she replied.
Thank you, idiot.
Just one message.
Nothing more.
Nothing less.
Lily looked over my shoulder.
She smiled.
"Good news?"
I nodded.

"Aashika is going to be a mother."

Lily smiled warmly.

"She'll be a good one."

"I know."

Life had continued.

Exactly the way it was supposed to.

A few months later...

another hospital photograph appeared.

This time...

it wasn't from India.

It was ours.

Lily held my hand tightly.

Her eyes were wet.

She looked at me.

Smiled.

Then whispered...

"I think..."

"...our life is about to change forever."

I smiled back.

Not because I knew what the future would bring.

But because...

for the first time in many years...

I wasn't afraid of it anymore.

Outside the hospital window...

the rain had started.

Just like it always did.

Quietly.

Without asking anyone's permission.

Just like time.

Chapter Thirty-Three

A Different Kind of Happiness

There are moments in life...
that divide time into two parts.
Before.
And after.
The morning had started like every other weekday.
The alarm rang.
I woke up.
Made coffee.
Packed my laptop.
Looked at the clock.
Running late.
Again.
Lily hadn't come out of the bedroom yet.
Normally...
she was already in the kitchen by then.
I knocked gently.
"Lily?"
No answer.
I opened the door a little.
She was sitting near the window.
Quietly.
Holding something in her hands.
"You okay?"
I asked.
She looked up.
Smiled.
A smile unlike any I had seen before.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Not loud.
Not excited.
Just...
overwhelmed.
Without saying a word...
she held out a small white stick.
I looked at it.
For almost ten seconds...
my brain refused to understand.
Then...
my eyes slowly found the two pink lines.
I looked at Lily.
Looked back at the test.
Then at her again.
"Really...?"
My voice came out as little more than a whisper.
She nodded.
Tears had already started filling her eyes.
I stood there...
completely frozen.
She laughed softly through her tears.
"Say something..."
I opened my mouth.
Closed it again.
Nothing came out.
After everything life had shown me...
After all the places I had travelled...
After all the years that had passed...
I still couldn't find words for this moment.
Instead...
I slowly walked towards her.
Knelt down.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Placed both my hands around hers.
"We're..."
I stopped.
Still unable to believe it.
"We're going to be parents."
She nodded again.
This time...
she couldn't stop crying.
Neither could I.
For the next few minutes...
we simply sat there.
Holding each other's hands.
Smiling.
Crying.
Laughing.
Without speaking.
Outside...
people continued walking to work.
Cars passed by.
The city remained exactly the same.
But inside that small apartment...
our entire world had changed.
After nearly fifteen minutes...
Lily suddenly laughed.
"What?"
I asked.
"You know..."
"I've been waiting for you to say something
meaningful."
"I did."
"No."
"You just kept staring at the pregnancy test."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"I was processing."

"You were buffering."

I laughed.

"Maybe."

She leaned her head against my shoulder.

"So..."

"What now?"

I smiled.

"Now..."

"I think we call Amma."

The moment my mother answered the video call...
she knew.

She looked at our faces.

Then immediately asked,

"What happened?"

Neither of us answered.

Instead...

Lily quietly held the pregnancy test in front of the
camera.

For a second...

my mother didn't react.

Then...

her eyes widened.

"Ayyo..."

She covered her mouth.

"Really?"

I nodded.

She immediately started crying.

From somewhere behind the camera...

my father asked,

"What happened?"

She couldn't even answer properly.

She simply turned the phone towards him.
He adjusted his glasses.
Looked carefully.
Then slowly smiled.
That smile...
was enough.
Within five minutes...
the entire family knew.
My sister called.
My aunt called.
My uncle called.
Even relatives I hadn't spoken to in months somehow
found out.
Family WhatsApp became impossible to read.
Messages arrived every few seconds.
Blessings.
Voice notes.
Congratulations.
Baby name suggestions.
Completely unnecessary parenting advice.
Everything.
That evening...
the apartment looked exactly the same.
The furniture hadn't changed.
The walls hadn't changed.
The balcony hadn't changed.
Yet somehow...
everything felt different.
While arranging dinner...
Lily suddenly stopped.
"What?"
I asked.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

She smiled.
"We're not eating for two anymore."
I looked confused.
She gently placed her hand over her stomach.
"We're eating for three."
For a few seconds...
neither of us spoke.
I slowly walked towards her.
Very carefully...
I placed my hand beside hers.
Nothing could be felt.
Nothing could be seen.
And yet...
somewhere inside...
a tiny heartbeat had already begun.
That night...
I couldn't sleep.
Not because I was worried.
Because I kept imagining.
Tiny footsteps.
Small hands.
First words.
First birthday.
First day of school.
Teaching them Tamil.
Teaching them cricket.
Teaching them how to ride a bicycle.
Life had always moved forward.
But for the first time...
I wasn't wondering what I had lost.
I was wondering...
who was about to enter my life.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Before sleeping...
Lily looked at me.
"What are you smiling about?"
I laughed softly.
"I think..."
"I'm already becoming a father."
She smiled.
"No..."
She gently squeezed my hand.
"You're already becoming someone's home."
Outside...
the rain slowly tapped against the window.
Inside...
our little apartment suddenly felt much bigger.
Not because it had grown.
But because...
our future had.
The months passed quietly.
The apartment slowly began to change again.
Not because we bought new furniture.
Because we started making room...
for someone we hadn't even met yet.
The spare room slowly became a nursery.
Tiny clothes appeared inside cupboards.
Soft toys started filling empty shelves.
A small cradle stood near the window.
Every new item made everything feel a little more
real.
One Saturday afternoon...
I was trying to assemble the baby's crib.
After nearly an hour...

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

it still looked nothing like the picture on the instruction sheet.

Lily stood beside me.

Trying very hard not to laugh.

"You put it backwards."

"I know."

"No..."

"You don't."

I sighed.

"You want to help?"

She folded her arms proudly.

"I wanted to help forty minutes ago."

Twenty minutes later...

the crib finally stood upright.

Not perfectly.

But safely.

We both looked at it.

Neither of us spoke.

"It feels strange..."

I whispered.

"What does?"

"Someone's actually going to sleep there."

Lily smiled.

"And someone..."

She looked directly at me.

"...is going to panic every time the baby sneezes."

"I will not."

"You absolutely will."

She wasn't wrong.

That evening...

we video-called my parents.

Amma immediately asked,

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"Show me the room."
Lily turned the camera around.
The tiny crib.
The toys.
The little blankets.
Everything.
Amma smiled.
Then quietly wiped her eyes.
"What happened?"
I asked.
She laughed softly.
"Nothing."
"I was just thinking..."
"Yesterday..."
"I was preparing your room."
"And today..."
"You're preparing your child's."
For a few seconds...
none of us spoke.
Time had quietly completed another circle.
A few weeks later...
another photograph arrived in the family WhatsApp
group.
Aashika.
Holding her newborn baby.
Her husband standing beside her.
Both smiling.
The caption simply said,
"Welcome to our little world "
I smiled immediately.
Without thinking...
I typed,

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Congratulations.
She's beautiful.
A few minutes later...
my phone vibrated.
Aashika had replied privately.
"Thank you, idiot ."
I smiled.
Then locked my phone.
Lily looked at me.
"What happened?"
"Aashika's daughter was born."
Lily smiled warmly.
"I told you..."
"She'd be a wonderful mother."
I nodded.
"She is."
Outside...
the evening sky slowly turned orange.
Inside...
our own little family was quietly waiting...
for its newest member.
The last few weeks felt longer than the previous nine
months combined.
Every morning...
before leaving for work...
I asked the same question.
"You feeling okay?"
Lily smiled every single time.
"I'm fine."
Every evening...
I asked again.
"You sure?"

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She laughed.
"I promise."
One Friday afternoon...
while I was sitting in a meeting...
my phone began vibrating.
Lily Calling...
She never called me during office hours.
My heart skipped a beat.
I excused myself immediately and answered.
"Lily?"
Her voice was calm.
"I think..."
"...it's time."
For a second...
my mind went completely blank.
"What?"
"My contractions started."
There was a short pause.
"And..."
"I think you should come now."
"I'll be there."
I don't remember how I reached the parking lot.
I don't remember the traffic.
Or the signals.
Or the roads.
I only remember one thing.
I had never driven that carefully...
or that nervously.
By the time I reached home...
she was already waiting near the door.
A small hospital bag rested beside her.
She looked at me...

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and smiled.

"You look more scared than I am."

"I am."

She laughed softly.

"Good."

"It means you'll be a good father."

The drive to the hospital felt strangely quiet.

The radio played softly.

Rain tapped gently against the windshield.

Neither of us spoke much.

There wasn't anything to say.

A nurse guided us inside.

Doctors came and went.

Papers were signed.

Questions were asked.

Time suddenly stopped making sense.

"Mr. Mithran?"

A nurse smiled.

"You'll have to wait here."

The doors slowly closed behind Lily.

For the first time in years...

I felt completely helpless.

There was nothing I could do.

No problem I could solve.

No decision I could make.

All I could do...

was wait.

I sat in the hallway.

My phone remained tightly in my hand.

Every few minutes...

my mother called.

"Everything okay?"

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"I think so."
"Don't worry."
"I know."
But I did worry.
Every passing minute felt like an hour.
Then...
it happened.
A tiny cry echoed through the hallway.
The entire corridor suddenly became silent.
Not because the sound was loud.
Because it changed everything.
A few moments later...
the doctor walked out smiling.
"Congratulations."
"It's a healthy baby boy."
I didn't realise I was crying...
until I felt tears falling onto my hands.
The nurse gently carried him towards me.
"So..."
"Dad..."
"Would you like to hold him?"
My hands trembled.
"I've never held a baby before."
She smiled.
"You'll learn."
Very carefully...
she placed him in my arms.
He was so small.
His tiny fingers wrapped around one of mine.
Completely without knowing who I was.
And somehow...
at that exact moment...

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I understood something.
For years...
I had been searching for the meaning of love.
Now...
it was sleeping peacefully in my arms.
A little later...
I walked into Lily's room.
She looked exhausted.
But the moment she saw me holding our son...
she smiled.
"How is he?"
she whispered.
I looked down at him.
Then back at her.
"Perfect."
She smiled.
"So are you."
That evening...
another photograph appeared in the family
WhatsApp group.
Just three people.
Lily, Me And the tiniest member of our family.
Within seconds...
the group filled with blessings.
Congratulations, Heart emojis, Voice messages,
Family jokes.
Everyone celebrating.
Among all those messages...
one appeared quietly.
From Aashika.
"Congratulations, idiot. ❤️ He's lucky to have you."
I smiled.

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Typed only one sentence.

"Thank you."

Outside the hospital window...

the rain had finally stopped.

Inside...

our lives had begun again.

In the smallest heartbeat...

we had ever heard.

Chapter Thirty-Four

The Years We Never Noticed

The first year of becoming parents...
felt longer than every year before it.
Not because life had become difficult.
Because...
every day brought something new.
Our apartment no longer woke up with alarm clocks.
It woke up with tiny cries.
Sometimes at midnight.
Sometimes at three in the morning.
Sometimes...
every two hours.
Sleep slowly became a luxury.
One night...
I quietly walked into the kitchen to make milk.
Still half asleep...
I accidentally poured coffee powder into the baby's
bottle.
Lily walked in just in time.
She stared at the bottle.
Then at me.
Then started laughing so hard...
she had to sit down.
"You almost made him start office life early."
"I wasn't awake."
"I can see that."
The baby looked at both of us.
Completely confused.

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Then started laughing too.
That became our first family laugh.
Every milestone felt unbelievable.
The first smile.
The first tooth.
The first word.
The first step.
Nothing in my career...
No promotion.
No award.
No salary increase.
Ever made me happier...
than hearing one tiny voice say,
"Appa..."
for the very first time.
I stood frozen.
Lily smiled.
"I think..."
"He likes you."
I laughed.
"I hope so."
She looked at me.
"He loves you."
I quietly picked him up.
Held him close.
Years ago...
I had spent nights crying over losing someone.
Now...
I spent nights singing lullabies.
Life really had changed.
Weekends became different too.
Instead of shopping malls...

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we visited parks.
Instead of watching movies...
we watched cartoons.
Instead of sleeping late...
we woke up even earlier.
Somehow...
none of it felt like a sacrifice.
Because happiness had simply changed its shape.
One Sunday afternoon...
our son was trying to walk across the living room.
'Tiny steps.
Unsteady feet.
Both of us sitting nearby.
Ready to catch him if he fell.
He took one step.
'Then another.
'Then another.
Finally...
he reached me.
Without thinking...
I lifted him into my arms.
Lily quietly took a photograph.
I never knew...
that one ordinary photograph...
would become one of my favourites.
Months passed.
Birthdays came and went.
The apartment walls slowly filled with more
photographs.
The wedding picture...
was no longer in the centre.
Now...

the centre belonged to one smiling little boy.
Life had quietly rearranged our priorities.
Without asking us.
Sometimes...
late at night...
after putting him to sleep...
Lily and I sat on the balcony.
Exactly like we used to years ago.
Only now...
our conversations were different.
School.
Vaccinations.
Savings.
Family holidays.
We laughed.
"Remember..."
I asked.
"...when we thought buying furniture was stressful?"
She laughed.
"I'd happily assemble ten wardrobes..."
"...instead of convincing him to eat vegetables."
We both laughed.
Adulthood wasn't what either of us imagined.
It wasn't exciting every day.
It wasn't perfect.
But somehow...
it was beautiful.
Because beauty had stopped hiding inside
extraordinary moments.
It had quietly settled...
inside ordinary days.
One evening...

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while cleaning the living room...
our son found something underneath the sofa.
A small deck of colourful cards.
The YouKnow cards.
He picked them up.
"Appa..."
"What are these?"
I looked at the cards.
Smiled.
"They're from a very long time ago."
"Can we play?"
I looked at Lily.
She smiled.
"Of course."
We sat on the floor together.
Teaching him the same game...
that once carried one of the happiest...
and saddest memories of my life.
This time...
the game ended with laughter.
Not silence.
Outside...
another sunset quietly disappeared.
Inside...
another beautiful memory had just begun.
Five years.
That was how long it had been since I had last stayed
in India for more than a few weeks.
Every visit after that had been short.
A week.
Sometimes ten days.
Never enough.

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Work always waited for me in Australia.
Life always pulled me back.
This time...
things were different.
We had planned everything nearly six months in advance.
My parents wanted us to stay longer.
Our son had finally become old enough to enjoy travelling.
And Lily...
had been counting the days ever since the tickets were booked.
The moment the airplane touched the runway in Chennai...
I looked through the window.
The city lights stretched endlessly beneath us.
A strange smile appeared on my face.
"We're home."
I whispered.
Lily looked outside.
Then gently held my hand.
"I've missed this place."
"So have I."
The airport looked almost the same.
Crowded.
Loud.
People speaking Tamil everywhere.
Children running around.
Relatives waving excitedly.
Taxi drivers calling out to passengers.
It felt wonderfully chaotic.
As we walked through the arrival gate...

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I immediately spotted them.
Amma.
Standing exactly where she always stood.
Looking over every shoulder until she found me.
The moment our eyes met...
her face lit up.
"Mithra!"
I smiled.
Without thinking...
I walked faster.
She hugged me tightly.
Exactly the way she had when I first left for Australia.
Then she stepped back.
Looked at me carefully.
"You've put on weight."
I laughed.
"You used to say I looked thin."
"I changed my opinion."
Appa stood beside her smiling.
He hugged me quietly.
No words.
He never needed many.
Then he bent down.
Picked up his grandson.
"So..."
He smiled.
"Do you know who I am?"
Our son looked at him seriously for a few seconds.
Then answered confidently.
"Thatha."
Appa's eyes immediately filled with tears.
"I've been waiting to hear that."

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

The drive back home felt shorter than I remembered.
Every road brought another memory.
The tea shop where I stopped during college.
The old bakery.
The bus stand.
The bridge.
Everything looked smaller.
Or Maybe...
I had simply grown older.
When we reached home...
nothing had changed.
The same front gate.
The same jasmine plant.
The same swing.
Even the old clock inside the living room still ticked
loudly.
Amma smiled proudly.
"I didn't let your father change anything."
"Good."
I replied.
"It still feels like home."
That evening...
relatives slowly started arriving.
One by one.
Exactly the way they always had.
No invitations.
No planning.
Just...
"Someone heard Mithran has come."
The house quickly became noisy.
Children running everywhere.
Adults talking over one another.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Tea cups constantly being refilled.
Lily quietly sat beside Amma.
Learning another recipe.
For the hundredth time.
I watched them from across the room.
Smiled.
Years ago...
my mother had taught me how to eat.
Now...
she was teaching my wife how to cook.
Time really had completed another circle.
The next morning...
we all travelled to Kerala.
My aunt had insisted.
"You have to stay with us."
By afternoon...
we reached her house.
Standing outside that gate...
I became strangely quiet.
Lily noticed.
"Nervous?"
I smiled.
"A little."
She gently squeezed my hand.
Then rang the bell.
The door opened.
Athai smiled immediately.
"Mithran!"
She hugged me tightly.
Then welcomed all of us inside.
The house looked different.
New furniture.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Fresh paint.
More family photographs.
Yet somehow...
it still carried the same warmth.
A few minutes later...
I heard familiar footsteps coming down the stairs.
Aashika.
She smiled.
Exactly the same smile.
Only a little more mature.
Beside her stood her husband.
Holding their little daughter.
For a brief second...
all four of us simply smiled at one another.
No awkwardness.
No silence.
No pain.
Only...
time.
"Long time."
She said.
"Too long."
I replied.
She looked at Lily.
Walked forward.
Hugged her warmly.
"You finally came."
Lily laughed.
"I've been waiting for this trip."
Aashika then bent down towards our son.
"Hi..."
He immediately hid behind my leg.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Everyone laughed.
"My daughter did the same."
Aashika smiled.
A few moments later...
both children were already running around the house
together.
Playing.
Laughing.
Fighting over toys.
Making more noise than all the adults combined.
We all sat together in the living room.
Talking about work.
Children.
Parents.
Travelling.
Life.
No one spoke about July.
No one spoke about the past.
Some memories didn't need conversations.
They simply existed.
Quietly.
That evening...
before dinner...
my aunt suddenly clapped her hands.
"Everyone outside!"
We all looked confused.
"What happened?"
She disappeared inside the bedroom.
Came back carrying an old photo album.
She smiled mischievously.
"I found something."
She opened one page.

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BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

There it was.
A faded photograph.
Two children.
Standing together.
Smiling at the camera.
Without knowing...
how many years life would carry them.
Athai laughed.
"Stand exactly like this."
Everyone smiled.
I looked at Aashika.
She looked back at me.
Then both of us laughed.
Without saying anything...
we stood in the same places.
This time..
not as children.
Not as teenagers.
Not as two people carrying misunderstandings.
Just...
family.
The camera clicked.
Two photographs.
Twenty years apart.
One captured childhood.
The other...
captured everything that survived it.
That evening...
the house was louder than it had been all day.
Children ran from one room to another.
Someone switched on the television.
My uncle was arguing with my father about cricket.

My aunt kept asking everyone to eat more.
Nothing had changed.
And yet...
everything had.
Dinner was served on banana leaves.
Exactly the way our family always preferred.
The dining table wasn't enough anymore.
Some of us sat on chairs.
Some on the floor.
The children somehow managed to sit everywhere
except where they were supposed to.
My son looked at the food in front of him.
Then whispered,
"Appa..."
"What is this?"
I smiled.
"Sambar."
"And this?"
"Poriyal."
"And this?"
"Appalam."
He looked completely confused.
Then slowly asked,
"Can I just eat curd rice?"
The entire room burst into laughter.
My mother shook her head.
"Exactly like his father."
"I wasn't that bad."
I protested.
Amma immediately replied,
"You refused vegetables until you were ten."
Lily looked at me with a smile.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"So..."

"Our son inherited everything."

"Apparently."

After dinner...

everyone moved outside.

The night breeze felt cool.

Children chased each other around the garden.

Parents sat together talking about old neighbours.

Grandparents watched everyone with quiet satisfaction.

I stood near the gate for a while.

Simply watching.

Years ago...

I was one of those children running around this very house.

Now...

I was the one telling a child,

"Don't run too fast."

Life had quietly changed my role.

Aashika walked over carrying two cups of tea.

She handed one to me.

"For you."

"Thanks."

For a few seconds...

we stood silently.

Looking at the children.

"They're becoming good friends."

She said.

I smiled.

"Looks like it."

"My daughter keeps talking about your son."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"He keeps talking about the chocolates your daughter gives him."

She laughed.

"Some things never change."

"No."

I replied.

"They don't."

The silence that followed wasn't uncomfortable.

It wasn't filled with unfinished conversations.

It wasn't carrying hidden emotions.

It was simply...

comfortable.

Like two people who had known each other for almost their entire lives.

After a while...

she looked towards the children.

Then quietly said,

"They're lucky."

I looked at her.

"They'll never know..."

"how complicated growing up can become."

I nodded slowly.

"I hope they never have to."

She smiled.

"So do I."

From inside the house...

my aunt shouted,

"Everyone come!"

We walked back together.

The living room had suddenly turned into a small photo studio.

Someone had brought a DSLR camera.

Tripods were being adjusted.
Children were refusing to stand still.
Parents were trying to arrange everyone.
It took nearly fifteen minutes...
just to make everyone look in the same direction.
"Ready?"
The photographer asked.
"No."
Half the family answered.
Everyone laughed.
Finally...
the countdown began.
"Three..."
My son suddenly looked away.
"Two..."
Someone sneezed.
"One..."
The camera clicked.
Another click.
Another.
The photographer looked satisfied.
"Perfect."
After everyone dispersed...
he walked over to me.
"Look."
He showed me the last photograph.
I stared at it quietly.
Four generations.
Parents.
Children.
Grandchildren.
Smiles everywhere.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Near the centre...
stood Aashika and her family.
A little away...
stood Lily, our son and me.
'There was no distance.
No separation.
No awkwardness.
Just...
one large family.
I smiled.
Not because life had become perfect.
Because...
despite everything...
life had been kind enough...
to leave us with this.
Later that night...
after everyone had gone to sleep...
I stepped onto the balcony.
'The same balcony...
where I had once stood as a confused twenty-year-old.
The city lights still stretched endlessly before me.
Only I had changed.
Behind me...
I heard small footsteps.
It was my son.
Still half asleep.
"Appa..."
"Hmm?"
He rubbed his eyes.
"When are we coming back here again?"
I picked him up.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Held him close.

"Soon."

He smiled sleepily.

"I like it here."

"So do I."

He rested his head on my shoulder.

Within seconds...

he had fallen asleep again.

I looked at the city one last time.

Then gently carried him back inside.

As I closed the balcony door...

I quietly whispered to myself...

"Some places never stop feeling like home."

That night...

I didn't know it.

But another year of my life...

had quietly come to an end.

Chapter Thirty-Five

Not Like This

Thirty-five.
I smiled at the number for a moment.
Not because it was special.
Because I still couldn't believe I had reached it.
There was a time...
when thirty-five felt unimaginably old.
Back then...
I was a college student.
Overthinking every message.
Waiting for every notification.
Believing life would somehow become easier.
It didn't.
It simply became...
different.
I stood in front of the bathroom mirror.
There were a few strands of grey hair near my
temples.
Not many.
Just enough to remind me...
that time had been quietly doing its job.
A small voice echoed through the hallway.
"Appaaaaa..."
I smiled before even turning around.
Tiny footsteps rushed across the wooden floor.
My son ran into the room...
still wearing dinosaur pajamas.
His hair pointed in every direction.

One sock was missing.
I had stopped asking where the other sock
disappeared months ago.
It had become one of life's greatest mysteries.
He wrapped both arms around my leg.
"Happy Birthday."
I bent down.
"So..."
"Who told you?"
He grinned proudly.
"Amma."
"I knew it."
He reached behind his back.
Pulled out a folded sheet of paper.
"I made this."
I carefully unfolded it.
It wasn't perfect.
The sun was purple.
The trees were blue.
The people looked like circles with stick arms.
At the center...
stood three figures.
One taller.
One slightly shorter.
One very tiny.
Holding hands.
Above them...
written in shaky handwriting...
were three words.
Our Family
I looked at the drawing for a long time.
Longer than he probably expected.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"Do you like it?"
he asked nervously.
I looked at him.
Then hugged him tightly.
"I love it."
Children have a beautiful way of making ordinary
paper...
feel priceless.
The smell of coffee slowly drifted through the
hallway.
Lily appeared carrying two mugs.
She smiled.
"So..."
"The birthday boy is already getting emotional?"
"I'm not emotional."
She raised an eyebrow.
"Your eyes disagree."
I laughed.
She handed me a mug.
Then looked at the drawing.
"I think..."
"He inherited your artistic skills."
I looked at the picture again.
"He definitely didn't inherit yours."
Our son looked confused.
"Is that good?"
Lily and I looked at each other.
Then laughed together.
The house slowly came alive.
Curtains opened.
Morning sunlight entered through the windows.
The kettle whistled.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Toast popped from the toaster.
The television quietly played cartoons in the
background.
Nothing extraordinary.
Just...
another ordinary morning.
Exactly the kind of morning...
I once dreamed of without even realizing it.
After breakfast...
I stepped into the backyard.
The grass was still wet from the night's rain.
Small drops of water rested on every leaf.
The air smelled fresh.
Peaceful.
I sat on the old wooden bench.
The same bench where I drank juice every Sunday
morning.
Thirty-five.
When did that happen?
I could still remember being twenty.
Crying silently on a bus leaving Kerala.
Holding a phone that never rang.
Wondering whether one decision had destroyed
everything.
That boy...
felt like someone else now.
Not because I had forgotten him.
Because I had forgiven him.
He was young.
He was scared.
He loved deeply.
He made mistakes.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Just like everyone does.
From inside the house...
I heard Lily laughing.
Then my son laughing even louder.
The kind of laughter that fills an entire home.
Without thinking...
I smiled.
Maybe...
this was happiness.
Not excitement.
Not achievement.
Not success.
Just knowing...
that the people you love...
were inside the house.
Waiting for you.
My phone vibrated.
Family
One new message.
I looked at the screen.
Smiled.
But didn't open it immediately.
Instead...
I watched the morning breeze move through the
trees.
Listening to birds I still couldn't identify after all these
years in Australia.
Life had taught me something.
Not every notification needed to be opened
immediately.
Some moments...
deserved to be lived first.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I finished my coffee.
Took one deep breath.
Then quietly unlocked my phone.
I unlocked my phone.
The notification bar showed only one unread
message.
Family
No missed calls.
No urgent notifications.
Just...
one message.
I opened the group.
As always...
there were dozens of messages.
My sister had replied with laughing emojis.
Someone wished another cousin on their birthday.
My mother had sent pictures of the jasmine flowers
blooming in our garden.
Nothing unusual.
Just another ordinary morning.
I slowly scrolled through them.
Not because I had to.
Because reading those conversations somehow made
the distance between Australia and India feel smaller.
Then...
a new photograph appeared.
It had been sent only a minute ago.
I tapped on it.
A family picture.
Aashika.
Her husband.
Their two children.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Her parents.
Everyone standing together in front of their house.
The youngest child was making a funny face.
The older one wasn't even looking at the camera.
Her husband was laughing instead of smiling.
Aashika looked exactly the same.
Only...
a little older.
A little calmer.
A little more like someone who had finally found
peace.
The caption underneath simply read:
"Sunday lunch at home "
Nothing more.
Nothing emotional.
Just...
another family photograph.
I smiled.
Not because of the photograph itself.
Because life had continued exactly the way it was
supposed to.
Without thinking...
I zoomed into the picture.
Not to look at Aashika.
To look at the house.
The old balcony was still there.
The swing near the entrance hadn't changed.
The mango tree looked much taller.
The wall had been repainted.
Some places somehow remain familiar...
even after years.
Behind me...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I heard little footsteps.
My son slowly walked outside.
Still carrying his favourite dinosaur.
He climbed onto the bench beside me.
"What are you looking at?"
I turned the phone towards him.
"Our family."
He looked carefully.
"Who's that?"
He pointed at my uncle.
"That's your Periappa."
"And her?"
He pointed at my aunt.
"Periamma."
He continued pointing at everyone.
Patiently waiting for every answer.
Then...
his tiny finger stopped on Aashika.
"And her?"
For a brief moment...
I simply looked at the screen.
Then I smiled.
"She's..."
I paused.
Searching for the simplest answer.
"...someone who's been part of our family for a very
long time."
He nodded as though that explained everything.
Children never needed complicated answers.
Then he pointed at her daughter.
"Can she play with me again?"
I smiled immediately.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"I think she'd like that."
He grinned happily.
"Next time we go to India?"
"Yes."
"Promise?"
I gently held out my little finger.
"Promise."
He wrapped his tiny finger around mine.
Exactly the way I used to do with my sister years ago.
Then he jumped down from the bench.
"I'm going to tell Amma."
Before I could stop him...
he had already disappeared inside the house.
I laughed quietly.
Children always lived in the future.
Adults...
spent too much time visiting the past.
A few minutes later...
my phone vibrated again.
This time...
a private message.
Aashika
For a second...
I simply stared at her name.
There was no nervousness.
No racing heartbeat.
No fear.
Just...
familiarity.
I opened the chat.
The message contained only one photograph.
It was the same picture.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

But this time...
cropped differently.
Only the children.
Below it...
she had written,
"They've been asking when they'll see Australia again."
"
I smiled.
I replied,
"Tell them they're always welcome."
A few seconds passed.
Typing...
Then another message appeared.
"Happy Birthday, idiot. "
I couldn't help smiling.
Some nicknames never disappear.
No matter how old we become.
I typed,
"Thank you. "
I almost pressed send.
Then stopped.
After thinking for a second...
I added another line.
"Hope everyone is doing well."
I pressed send.
A few moments later...
her reply arrived.
"Everyone's good."
"Hope all of you are happy too."
I looked towards the living room.
Lily was sitting on the floor.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Helping our son build something with colourful
blocks.
Both of them were laughing.
Completely unaware that I was watching.
I smiled.
Then looked back at my phone.
I typed only one word.
"Always."
Seen.
Nothing else.
No long conversation.
No unnecessary questions.
No reopening old memories.
The chat ended exactly where it should.
I locked the phone.
Slipped it back into my pocket.
Then leaned back against the wooden bench.
The morning breeze moved gently through the trees.
Birds landed on the fence.
Clouds slowly drifted across the sky.
For years...
I had believed closure arrived through conversations.
Through explanations.
Through apologies.
I was wrong.
Sometimes...
closure arrived quietly.
Through one ordinary message.
One family photograph.
One simple word.
Always.
For the first time in many years...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

that word wasn't a promise.
It was simply...
the truth.
The rest of the day passed quietly.
Birthdays had become much simpler over the years.
There were no grand celebrations.
No crowded halls.
No loud music.
No expensive gifts.
Just...
the people who mattered.
By evening...
our backyard had been transformed into a small
celebration.
Nothing extravagant.
A few fairy lights hung across the fence.
A wooden table stood beneath the old tree.
Paper lanterns swayed gently whenever the wind
passed.
Our son had insisted on blowing balloons himself.
Half of them were different sizes.
One had already burst.
Another had somehow floated onto the roof.
He proudly called it
"Modern decoration."
Lily laughed every time she looked at it.
As the sun slowly disappeared...
friends began arriving.
Neighbours.
Colleagues.
A few families we had grown close to over the years.
Children immediately took over the backyard.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Within minutes...
footballs rolled across the grass.
Soap bubbles floated through the air.
Tiny bicycles lay abandoned near the gate.
The adults talked.
The children created chaos.
Exactly the way every family gathering should.
Someone switched on soft music.
Not loud enough to interrupt conversations.
Just enough to fill the silence between them.
I stood near the barbecue.
Trying very hard to pretend I knew what I was doing.
One of my neighbours looked at the burnt vegetables.
Then looked at me.
"First time?"
I smiled.
"Does it show?"
He laughed.
"A little."
Lily walked over.
Looked at the food.
Then quietly took the tongs from my hand.
"I'll save dinner."
"I was doing fine."
She raised one eyebrow.
"The vegetables disagree."
Everyone nearby laughed.
I shook my head.
"Thirty-five years old..."
"...and I'm still getting fired from cooking."
Our son immediately shouted from the garden,
"Because Amma is the boss!"

The entire backyard erupted with laughter.
Later that evening...
after dinner...
the cake was placed on the table.
It wasn't huge.
Just a simple chocolate cake.
Exactly the way I liked it.
Thirty-five tiny candles would have been impossible.
So, our son placed only one.
He looked at me very seriously.
"Appa..."
"You have to make one wish."
I smiled.
"What if I tell you my wish?"
He immediately covered both ears.
"No!"
"It won't come true."
Children believe in magic.
Adults pretend they don't.
I closed my eyes.
For only a second.
Not asking for success.
Not asking for money.
Not asking for a longer life.
Only one thought quietly crossed my mind.
Let the people I love stay healthy.
That was enough.
I opened my eyes.
Blew out the candle.
Everyone clapped.
Our son looked disappointed.
"You didn't tell me your wish."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I smiled.
"I'll tell you when you're thirty-five."
He thought about it.
Then nodded seriously.
"Okay."
To him...
thirty-five probably sounded ancient.
Later...
after everyone had eaten...
the children gathered around me.
"Story!"
one of them shouted.
Another immediately agreed.
I looked at Lily.
She smiled.
"They won't sleep until you tell one."
I sat down on the grass.
The children formed a small circle around me.
"What story?"
someone asked.
I looked up at the stars.
Thought for a moment.
Then smiled.
"I'll tell you..."
"...about two children."
"They were cousins."
"They fought."
"They laughed."
"They played games."
"They made handmade gifts."
"They annoyed each other."
"They grew up."

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

"And one day..."
I stopped.
The children waited.
"What happened?"
I smiled gently.
"They became adults."
"That's it?"
one little girl asked.
I nodded.
"Sometimes..."
"The happiest stories don't need dragons."
"They just need good people."
The children looked slightly disappointed.
They had expected monsters.
Not ordinary life.
Still...
they clapped.
Then immediately ran away to continue playing.
I remained sitting there.
Watching them disappear into the garden.
Lily quietly came and sat beside me.
"That wasn't really a children's story."
"I know."
"It was yours."
I looked at her.
She smiled.
"I've known that for years."
For a moment...
neither of us spoke.
The fairy lights reflected softly in her eyes.
The laughter of children echoed across the yard.
The smell of rain drifted through the evening air.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?

BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

She gently rested her head against my shoulder.
"I'm proud of you."
she whispered.
"For what?"
She looked at our son.
Running across the grass.
Laughing without a care in the world.
"For choosing to keep living."
I didn't answer.
Because I knew...
she wasn't talking about Australia.
Or marriage.
Or work.
She was talking about a decision made many years
ago.
One that had broken me.
One that had slowly taught me how to rebuild myself.
I looked around the backyard.
Friends laughing.
Children playing.
Music drifting through the night.
The woman I loved sitting beside me.
Life hadn't become perfect.
But it had become...
beautiful.
And for the first time...
I realized something.
I no longer measured my life...
by the people I had lost.
I measured it...
by the people waiting for me inside the house.
The night grew quieter.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

One by one...
the guests began leaving.
The fairy lights continued glowing.
The balloons swayed gently in the wind.
Our son had fallen asleep on the sofa...
still holding one tiny piece of birthday cake in his
hand.
Lily carefully carried him to bed.
I remained outside.
Looking at the stars.
Listening to the silence.
Somewhere inside the house...
my laptop waited.
One page remained unwritten.
I took one last look at the backyard.
At the home we had built.
At the life we had created.
Then I quietly walked towards my study.
Closed the door behind me.
Sat down.
Opened the laptop.
The cursor blinked.
Waiting.
Can Love Survive?
I smiled.
"Yes..."
I whispered.
"...I think it can."
The house had finally fallen silent.
The laughter that had filled every corner only an hour
ago had slowly faded into memories.
The balloons still floated lazily near the ceiling.

One had already begun to lose its air.
The birthday banner hung slightly crooked.
Wrapping paper remained untouched near the sofa.
A tiny toy dinosaur slept beside it.
Our son must have forgotten to carry it to bed.
I smiled.
Some messes deserved to remain until morning.
The hallway lights were switched off one by one.
Only the warm yellow light from my study remained.
The same room.
The same wooden desk.
The same window that looked into the backyard.
The same chair where countless nights had quietly disappeared.
I gently closed the study door.
Not because I wanted privacy.
Because I wanted silence.
The rain had returned.
Soft.
Patient.
Almost respectful.
Tiny drops tapped against the window as though they knew tonight mattered.
I walked towards the bookshelf.
Ran my fingers slowly across the spines of old books.
College textbooks.
Programming books.
Travel journals.
Family albums.
And finally...
one empty space.
Waiting.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I smiled to myself.
"Not for much longer."
On the desk...
my laptop was still awake.
The cursor blinked patiently.
Waiting for the last few words.
Waiting...
for me.
I sat down.
The wooden chair made the same familiar sound it
always had.
Some noises become part of a home.
For a long time...
I didn't touch the keyboard.
Instead...
I simply watched the rain.
Rain had followed so many important moments of
my life.
The night I cried on the bus.
The day I arrived in Australia.
The afternoon our son was born.
Today.
Maybe...
rain never meant sadness.
Maybe...
it simply reminded me that life keeps falling...
one moment at a time.
I slowly opened the manuscript.
Nearly seven hundred pages.
Thirty-five chapters.
Twenty years.
Thousands of memories.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Hundreds of conversations.
Laughter.
Silence.
Mistakes.
Forgiveness.
Growth.
Every page carried a version of me that no longer
existed.
I turned to the final chapter.
The cursor blinked beneath the last paragraph.
Still unfinished.
I placed both hands on the keyboard.
Closed my eyes.
Then...
began typing.
Some people become our future.
I stopped.
Read it once.
Then continued.
Some become our greatest lesson.
Outside...
the wind gently moved the branches of the trees.
I continued.
Some become the reason we learn how to love others
better.
Silence.
Three sentences.
Twenty years...
reduced to three sentences.
I smiled.
Then...
I reached the final paragraph.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

The hardest one.
The paragraph I had rewritten more times than I
could remember.
This time...
the words came without hesitation.
Thank you, Aashika.
Not because...
you became my forever.
But because...
losing our friendship taught me...
how precious it truly was.
If I could change only one thing in my life...
It wouldn't be...
to make you love me.
It would be...
to make sure...
I never lost my best friend.
I stopped typing.
Looked at the screen.
Read every word again.
For years...
I thought this sentence would destroy me.
Instead...
it set me free.
A single tear rolled down my cheek.
Not from pain.
Not from regret.
Not even from sadness.
From gratitude.
Gratitude...
for every person who had quietly shaped the man I
had become.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I moved the cursor one final time.
Typed two simple words.

‘THE END’

I leaned back.
Closed my eyes.
And slowly exhaled.
It was finished.
Not the novel.
That had ended chapters ago.
This...
was the goodbye.
At that exact moment...
my phone vibrated softly.
One notification.
Aashika
For a second...
I simply looked at her name.
Not with excitement.
Not with fear.
Only with familiarity.
I opened the message.
A photograph appeared.
She stood beside her husband.
Their children smiled in front of them.
Behind them...
stood the same house where we had once played as
children.
The same mango tree.
The same front gate.
The same sky.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Below the photograph...
she had written:
Happy Birthday, idiot.
Hope you and your family had a wonderful day.
I smiled.
A real smile.
The kind that carried no weight.
I typed slowly.
Thank you.
We did.
I hope all of you are happy too.
A few moments later...
her reply arrived.
We are.
That was all.
No memories.
No questions.
No apologies.
No explanations.
None were needed anymore.
I locked my phone.
Placed it beside the laptop.
Then...
I stood up.
Walked towards the bookshelf.
Reached for the old wooden box.
Its surface had become smoother with age.
The tiny scratch near the corner was still there.
The brass latch made the same soft click when I
opened it.
Inside...
lay pieces of a life that never happened.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

A faded birthday note.
The old train ticket.
A dried flower.
The colourful YouKnow cards.
A handmade gift.
The selfie from her sister's wedding.
A childhood photograph with two smiling children
who knew nothing about heartbreak.
I picked up the photograph.
Looked at it for a long time.
Then I smiled.
"You two..."
I whispered.
"...had no idea how life was going to unfold."
I placed it back gently.
Exactly where it belonged.
I looked at the finished manuscript resting on my
desk.
For a moment...
I thought about placing it inside the box.
Then I quietly shook my head.
"No."
"The memories belong in here."
I touched the wooden box.
"But the story..."
I looked at the manuscript.
"...belongs to the world."
I closed the lid.
Very gently.
The soft click echoed through the silent room.
It wasn't the sound of forgetting.
It was the sound of accepting.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

I placed the box back on the shelf.
Beside the manuscript.
Past.
And purpose.
Standing side by side.
Before leaving the room...
I switched off the desk lamp.
Only the moonlight remained.
I looked back one final time.
The wooden box.
The completed manuscript.
The quiet room.
Then...
I smiled.
Opened the door.
And walked towards the people waiting for me.
Thousands of kilometres away...
Aashika was living the life she had chosen.
She had a loving husband.
Children who adored her.
A home filled with laughter.
Dreams she had built with her own hands.
I had mine too.
We no longer shared the same road.
But once...
our paths had crossed.
And that...
was enough.
Neither of us had failed.
Neither of us had won.
Life had simply written...
two different endings...

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

to the same beginning.
At twenty...
I believed love meant ending up with the person you
loved.
At thirty-five...
I finally understood.
Sometimes...
love survives.
Not as a relationship.
Not as a promise.
Not as a dream waiting to come true.
Sometimes...
it survives...
as a memory.
A lesson.
A quiet thank you.
And sometimes...
that's enough.
Can Love Survive?
Turn the page.
Yes.
Turn the page.
But sometimes...
Turn the page.
It survives only as a memory.

THE END

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

If I stay, then I lose myself
If I leave, then I lose you
If I wait, then it'll never be me
If I move on it'll never, be you
So, what do I do?
Do I make a left but there's nothing
right
Or a right where there's nothing left

– MRETYUN JAI

*"Every chapter has an
ending.
Some endings become
memories.
Some memories become
stories.
Thank you for reading
mine."*

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

From the Author to the Real Person,

This story is the possibility that “What if I started loving you? Like one-sided love”, I don’t want you to love me back, we can’t love each other due some reasons, so don’t take it as big deal and just enjoy the story and understand the poor guy and thanks for the good memories that we made together, I hope that you will be happy

Thank You

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Every decision creates a future.

Mithran made one choice.

One argument.

One night.

One future.

But...

What if he had chosen differently?

What if...

instead of arguing...

he had simply stayed?

The story isn't over.

It has another beginning.

B) Only If It Waits

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

To my parents,

Thank you for teaching me that every story
deserves to be finished.

To my readers,

Thank you for walking beside Mithran
through every chapter.

To my AYK,

Thanks for everything.

Thank you for reading.
If Mithran's story stayed with you...
then perhaps...
love really can survive.

CAN LOVE SURVIVE?
BOOK ONE • NOT LIKE THIS

Written by
MRETYUN JAI B

**"Every page began with a
memory."**

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